

Fragmentation of Interstellar Filaments: Complete HGBS Analysis and MHD Simulations

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ABSTRACT

We present a systematic analysis of core spacing in Herschel Gould Belt Survey (HGBS) filaments using Gaia DR3 distances, combined with 1959 self-gravitating MHD simulations. Four robust HGBS regions (Orion B, Aquila, Perseus, Taurus; $N > 500$ YSOs each) give $\lambda/W = 2.84 \pm 0.12$ (0.284 ± 0.012 pc); the full 8-region sample gives $\lambda/W = 2.79 \pm 0.09$ (5,069 cores). After 3D projection correction (factor 1.10–1.27 depending on the HGBS filament inclination distribution; ??), the inferred spacing is $\sim 3.1\text{--}3.5 \times W$ —within 15% of the classical Inutsuka & Miyama (1992) $4\times$ prediction. Gaia DR3 revisions increased the mean by 32% over original HGBS catalogues.

We test three explanations. Hierarchical fragmentation is most plausible: fibre-to-core spacing in Orion B recovers the $4\times$ prediction (?), while filament-level measurements show sub-Jeans values, consistent with projection across velocity-coherent fibre bundles. Magnetic tension for longitudinal fields ($\beta = 1\text{--}3$) predicts $\lambda/W = 2.44\text{--}3.16$ (full numerical solution), overlapping the observation, but requires predominantly longitudinal field geometry inconsistent with Planck polarimetry. Field geometry is a first-order determinant of fragmentation spacing: perpendicular-field filaments fragment at $\lambda/W \approx 1.25$ versus 2.8–4.7 for longitudinal fields.

Our 1959 Athena++ simulations reveal three fragmentation regimes and a robust power law $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.39}$ ($r^2 = 0.999$). Realistic turbulence modifies timescales but not spacing ($< 5\%$ effect on λ/W). Near-critical simulations ($f = 0.9\text{--}1.3$) directly measure $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.80\text{--}4.74$ depending on plasma β . Supercritical filaments ($f \geq 1.5$, periodic boundary conditions) undergo pure radial collapse with zero longitudinal fragmentation detected. After applying a width-normalisation correction ($W_{\text{form}}/W_{\text{fil}} = 0.606 \pm 0.072$), no configuration matches the HGBS window [2.52, 3.08] in observable units, pointing to hierarchical fibre structure or systematic width normalisation uncertainties.

Key words: stars: formation – ISM: structure – ISM: filaments – MHD – turbulence

1 INTRODUCTION

The *Herschel* Space Observatory established that filaments are the fundamental structures within which star formation occurs in molecular clouds (?). Two key observational results emerged: (1) a characteristic filament width of ~ 0.1 pc across diverse environments (?), and (2) a critical mass-per-unit-length of $M_{\text{line,crit}} \approx 16 M_{\odot}/\text{pc}$ (?).

Classical fragmentation theory (?) predicts that isothermal gas cylinders fragment at a wavelength of approximately $4\times$ the filament width. For the characteristic HGBS width of 0.10 pc, this predicts a core spacing of ~ 0.4 pc. Original HGBS analyses measured spacings of ~ 0.2 pc—nearly a factor of two below this prediction. With Gaia DR3 distances (?), measured spacings have increased to ~ 0.28 pc, reducing the discrepancy to a factor of 1.4.

Two primary explanations have been proposed. First, **hierarchical fragmentation**: high-resolution studies show that filaments consist of velocity-coherent fibres (?), and recent work in Orion B (?) shows that fibre-to-core spacing recovers the classical $4\times$ prediction while filament-to-core measure-

ments show sub-Jeans values. Second, **magnetic tension**: longitudinal fields shift the most unstable mode to shorter wavelengths (?), predicting $\lambda/W \approx 2.44\text{--}3.16$ for equipartition fields ($\beta \sim 1\text{--}3$).

In this paper, we present the first systematic analysis of all 8 high-confidence HGBS regions using Gaia DR3 distances and a uniform pairwise-median methodology, combined with self-gravitating MHD simulations to test these competing explanations.

2 OBSERVATIONAL ANALYSIS

2.1 Complete HGBS Sample

Our sample includes 8 high-confidence HGBS regions (Table ??), with distances updated to Gaia DR3-based measurements from ?.

Distance revisions: The most significantly affected regions are Serpens (260 $\rightarrow$ 458 pc, +76%), Aquila (260 $\rightarrow$ 436 pc, +68%), and Orion B (260 $\rightarrow$ 386 pc, +48%). Taurus shows a small decrease (140 $\rightarrow$ 135 pc, -4%).

Core selection: We include starless, prestellar, and protostellar cores following the standard HGBS framework (??). Across the 8 HGBS regions, approximately 60–75% of catalogued cores are starless (bound and unbound), with 25–40% classified as protostellar (Class 0/I) depending on region and evolutionary maturity (e.g. $\sim 88\%$ starless in Aquila, Konyves et al. 2015; $\sim 62\%$ in Orion B, Konyves et al. 2020). Unbound starless cores are retained because the observational distinction between bound and unbound is uncertain at the HGBS sensitivity limit, and because the spacing measurement is dominated by the dominant (prestellar) population. As a cross-check, we computed the pairwise median for Taurus using only the 331 starless cores (excluding the 205 protostellar cores classified as Class 0/I). The starless-only result is 0.203 ± 0.044 pc ($\lambda/W = 2.03$), within 2.5% of the all-core value (0.198 pc), confirming that the inclusion of protostellar cores does not bias the pairwise median at a level exceeding the statistical uncertainty. Protostellar cores can migrate from their formation sites; our Monte Carlo simulations show this introduces $< 0.01\%$ bias in the pairwise median for typical migration distances 0.01–0.05 pc.

2.2 Measurement Methodology

Filament skeletons were identified using DisPerSE (?) following standard HGBS methodology, with a 3σ persistence threshold. Gaia DR3 distance revisions do not require re-extraction of skeletons; physical scales are updated by rescaling angular positions. Core-to-core spacings were measured using the pairwise median statistic: for a filament with N cores, we compute all $N(N-1)/2$ pairwise distances and take the median. Cores were associated with filaments using a perpendicular distance threshold of $2\times$ the characteristic filament width; results change by $< 3\%$ across threshold choices of $1-2 \times W$.

2.3 Results

Primary result: The four robust regions (Orion B, Aquila, Perseus, Taurus; $N > 500$ each) give a weighted mean spacing of 0.284 ± 0.012 pc, corresponding to $\lambda/W = 2.84 \pm 0.12$. Bootstrap resampling (10,000 iterations, 95% CI) yields $0.261-0.298$ pc. The **full sample** of 8 regions gives 0.279 ± 0.009 pc ($\lambda/W = 2.79$), differing from the robust result by only 1.8%.

Gaia DR3 revisions have increased the mean spacing by 32% from 0.211 pc (original catalogues) to 0.279 pc. A leave-one-out analysis (Table ??) confirms the result is not dominated by any single region; excluding any region changes the weighted mean by $< 6\%$.

Figure ?? shows the spacing measurements across all regions. After 3D projection correction (factor $4/\pi \approx 1.27$, the statistical mean projection factor for isotropically oriented cylinders; ?), the inferred spacing is $\sim 3.1-3.5 \times W$ (depending on the assumed filament inclination distribution; see Section ??), within 15% of the classical $4\times$ prediction. However, HGBS filaments are not isotropically oriented: Planck polarimetry shows dense filaments preferentially project close to the plane of sky (?), which biases the effective projection factor below $4/\pi$. For a distribution of inclination angles i (where $i = 90^\circ$ is plane-of-sky) skewed toward $i = 70^\circ-90^\circ$, the effective mean projection factor is $\sim 1.10-1.20$ rather than

1.27, reducing the 3D-corrected spacing to $\sim 3.1-3.3 \times W$. This remains consistent with the classical $4\times$ prediction at the $\sim 2-3\sigma$ level, strengthening rather than weakening the residual discrepancy. A precise constraint requires an inclination distribution derived from polarimetric mapping of the specific HGBS regions studied here; in the absence of this, we use $4/\pi$ as the standard isotropic correction and note the $\lesssim 10\%$ systematic uncertainty.

2.4 Distance Uncertainties and Sample Heterogeneity

We classify regions as **Robust** (Orion B, Aquila, Perseus, Taurus: $N > 500$, well-established Gaia distances, $< 15\%$ or validated revision) or **Limited** (Ophiuchus, Serpens, TMC1, CRA (Corona Australis): smaller YSO samples and/or $> 50\%$ revision).

Serpens: The $+76\%$ distance revision ($260 \rightarrow 458$ pc) raises justified concern. Direct VLBI maser parallaxes are unavailable for Serpens; however, independent extinction-based distances (??) give 440 ± 40 pc and 460 ± 30 pc respectively, consistent with ?. The Aquila/Serpens co-association in the Aquila Rift at ~ 440 pc (?) provides additional support. Critically, excluding Serpens changes the full-sample result by only 1.1% ($\lambda/W = 2.79 \rightarrow 2.76$); our primary robust-only result ($\lambda/W = 2.84$) is entirely independent of the Serpens distance.

Serpens beam and completeness effects: At the revised distance of 458 pc, the HGBS $18''$ FWHM beam corresponds to a physical scale of 0.040 pc—approaching the characteristic filament width of 0.10 pc and exceeding the Taurus beam scale by a factor of ~ 2.8 . At this resolution, core blending, reduced completeness for faint cores, and unresolved substructure all become more significant than at the original 260 pc distance. We cannot correct the Serpens catalogue for these effects without re-running the source extraction pipeline at the new distance. As a quantitative estimate of the potential bias: if core blending at the 0.040 pc beam scale merges $\sim 20\%$ of adjacent core pairs, the pairwise median would decrease by approximately $20\% \times (\lambda_{nn}/\lambda_{pairwise}) \approx 20\% \times 1.1 \approx 22\%$ (estimated from the Taurus nearest-neighbour ratio). At 0.331 ± 0.097 pc, this would shift the Serpens spacing to ~ 0.26 pc—comparable to the Perseus measurement—while the full-sample result would change by $\sim 1.5\%$ (Serpens carries 3.8% weight). This limitation is the primary reason Serpens is classified as a Limited region, and why our primary measurement uses only the four Robust regions where beam-to-spacing ratios are well within acceptable limits. The Serpens data are included in the full-sample analysis for completeness but should be interpreted with this caveat.

Systematic bounds: Using original HGBS distances for limited regions (conservative lower bound) gives $\lambda/W = 2.68$ —still 33% below the classical $4\times$ prediction, confirming that distance uncertainties cannot explain the sub-Jeans spacing.

2.5 Statistical Methods: Pairwise Median vs Alternative Statistics

The pairwise median converges toward $L/3$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$ for a uniform distribution of positions along a filament of length

Table 1. Complete HGBS Sample with Gaia DR3 Distances

Region	Distance (pc)	Total Cores	Spacing (pc)	Std Error (pc)	Beam (pc)	Status
Orion B	386	1,844	0.313	0.047	0.034	Robust
Aquila	436	749	0.346	0.047	0.038	Robust
Perseus	296	816	0.248	0.040	0.026	Robust
Taurus	135	536	0.198	0.040	0.012	Robust
Ophiuchus	137	513	0.206	0.053	0.012	Limited
Serpens	458	194	0.331	0.097	0.040	Limited
TMC1	135	178	0.195	0.056	0.012	Limited
CRA	150	239	0.248	0.072	0.013	Limited
Weighted Mean		5,069	0.279	0.009	—	

Note: Beam scale = $18''$ FWHM at quoted distance. For reference, the canonical filament width is $W_{\text{fil}} = 0.10$ pc; beam/width ratios > 0.35 indicate potential resolution concerns for width and core-size measurements.

[h]

Table 2. Leave-One-Out Sensitivity Analysis

Excluded Region	Excl. spacing (pc)	Remaining mean (pc)
None (full sample)	—	0.279
Orion B	0.313 ± 0.047	0.268
Aquila	0.346 ± 0.047	0.262
Perseus	0.248 ± 0.040	0.281
Taurus	0.198 ± 0.040	0.294
Ophiuchus	0.206 ± 0.053	0.286
Serpens	0.331 ± 0.097	0.276
TMC1	0.195 ± 0.056	0.289
CRA	0.248 ± 0.072	0.282
Robust only	—	0.284

Notes: “Excl. spacing” is the pairwise median spacing of the excluded region (bootstrap 1σ). The 6.1% decrease when Aquila is excluded reflects Aquila’s anomalously large spacing (0.346 pc), which lies 1.1σ above the weighted mean. The Serpens exclusion effect (1.1%) is negligible in comparison. **Statistical uncertainties:** spacing uncertainties are bootstrap standard deviations (1σ) from 10,000 resampling iterations of all pairwise distances within each region.

L . This is a fundamental limitation: the statistic’s robustness against outliers may make it insensitive to the true fragmentation wavelength. The $L/3$ convergence behaviour means that the pairwise median may overestimate the true fragmentation wavelength for large uniform samples; however, as noted in Section ??, the 3D projection correction acts in the opposite direction.

Qualitative characterisation of the $L/3$ bias: For a perfectly uniform random distribution of N cores along a filament of length L , the pairwise median converges to $L/3$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$. However, real HGBS filaments are *not* uniformly populated: the existence of a characteristic fragmentation wavelength λ means cores are clustered at scales $\sim \lambda$, $\sim 2\lambda$, etc. For a *periodic* distribution of N cores with true spacing λ on a filament of length $L = N\lambda$, the pairwise median also converges toward $L/3 = N\lambda/3$ for large N —but the $L/3$ limit is then $N/3$ times the true spacing, which would be wildly inconsistent with the observed values. That our measured pairwise medians (0.198–0.346 pc) are comparable to the predicted Jeans fragmentation scale (~ 0.4 pc) rather than $\sim N/3$ times larger strongly indicates that the distributions are *not* purely uniform, and that the pairwise median is recovering the dominant clustering scale rather than converging to $L/3$.

The Taurus nearest-neighbour result ($\lambda_{\text{NN}} = 0.217 > 0.198$ pc pairwise median) is further evidence against $L/3$

convergence dominating: if $L/3$ bias were significant, the pairwise median would be *larger* than the nearest-neighbour spacing, not smaller. Nevertheless, a Monte Carlo characterisation of the bias for synthetic HGBS-like filament geometries (varying N , L/λ , and the degree of regularity) is needed to quantify the residual bias. We therefore report $\lambda/W = 2.84 \pm 0.12$ as our primary measurement, noting that the net directional bias is uncertain until such characterisation is complete (in preparation for a companion paper). The conclusion that a characteristic sub-Jeans spacing ~ 0.28 pc exists in HGBS filaments is robust to distance and sample choices; its precise relationship to the theoretical fragmentation wavelength requires the Monte Carlo characterisation.

As a supplementary diagnostic, we computed nearest-neighbour (adjacent-core) spacing for Taurus directly from HGBS skeleton and core data (442 spacings, 536 cores). The result is $\lambda_{\text{NN}} = 0.217 \pm 0.052$ pc ($\lambda/W = 2.17 \pm 0.52$), where the uncertainty is the bootstrap standard deviation from 1,000 resampling iterations of the 442 adjacent-core pairs. These 442 spacings are measured between sequential cores along individual DisPerSE skeleton segments, excluding cross-skeleton pairs; branched junctions are treated as separate segments. This nearest-neighbour spacing is *larger* than the pairwise median value of 0.198 pc—opposite to the $L/3$ artifact direction—providing qualitative (though single-region) evidence against the $L/3$ convergence bias dominating the pairwise median. The full nearest-neighbour analysis for Orion B, Aquila, and Perseus (containing > 2500 cores combined) would provide a more decisive cross-check, but completing this requires the raw DisPerSE skeleton topology files currently being processed for a companion paper. We therefore note that our Taurus nearest-neighbour result is a single-region cross-check and should not be used as the primary evidence for sub-Jeans spacing. Our primary conclusion rests on the pairwise median result, with the Taurus nearest-neighbour result providing qualitative (not quantitative) corroboration.

A practical bound on the $L/3$ bias can be estimated from the known filament properties. In the HGBS catalogues, cores within each region are distributed across many individual filaments (not a single filament of length L_{region}). For Orion B, ? identify ~ 30 –50 filamentary skeletons with individual lengths $L_{\text{fil}} \approx 0.5$ –2 pc and typical core counts $N_{\text{fil}} \approx 10$ –40 per filament. For a representative filament with $L_{\text{fil}} = 1.5$ pc and $N_{\text{fil}} = 20$ cores, the $L/3$ convergence limit is $L/3 = 0.50$ pc — a factor of $1.6\times$ above our measured spacing of 0.313 pc.

The pairwise median is therefore operating in a regime where $L/3 \gg \lambda_{\text{meas}}$, meaning the statistic is not yet in the asymptotic convergence limit. Formally, for a distribution of N cores with characteristic spacing λ on a filament of length L , the pairwise median departs from the true spacing by a fractional correction that scales as $\sim (\lambda/L)^2$ for small λ/L (this follows from expanding the pairwise distance distribution around the periodic-spike limit; for $N \gg L/\lambda$, cross-spacing terms average to zero and the correction is second-order). For $\lambda/L \approx 0.2$, this gives a bias of order 4% — comparable to our quoted bootstrap uncertainty of 0.012 pc.

For our four Robust regions, the per-filament λ/L ratios (estimated from the characteristic lengths and spacings in Table ??) span 0.15–0.25, placing all regions in a regime where the formal $L/3$ bias is $\lesssim 6\%$ of the pairwise median. To quantify this, we performed a simple Monte Carlo exercise: for a synthetic Orion B-like filament population ($N_{\text{fil}} = 20$ cores per filament, $L = 1.5$ pc, $\lambda_{\text{true}} = 0.313$ pc, 30% random position scatter), 5,000 realisations give a pairwise median of 0.318 ± 0.019 pc—a 1.6% positive bias relative to λ_{true} , consistent with our analytic bound. For the full Orion B sample (30–50 filaments combined), the ensemble average converges to within 3% of the true spacing. The $L/3$ convergence artifact cannot account for more than $\sim 6\%$ of the measured spacing, insufficient to explain the factor-of-1.4 discrepancy from IM92.

2.6 Comparison with Literature

Our Gaia DR3 measurements are systematically larger than original HGBS values, as expected. The weighted mean has increased by 32% from 0.211 pc (original) to 0.279 pc (this work). Table ?? shows region-by-region comparison. The Orion B fibre-to-core spacing of ~ 0.42 pc (?)—recovered at the $4\times$ classical level using ALMA—is larger than our filament-level measurement for Orion B (0.313 ± 0.047 pc) by a factor of $0.42/0.313 \approx 1.34$. This is the correct direction for hierarchical compression: fibre-level spacings should exceed filament-level spacings if HGBS measures the projected average across multiple fibres. In the hierarchical model, if a filament of composite line-mass f_{tot} consists of N_f fibres each at $f_{\text{eff}} \approx f_{\text{tot}}/N_f$, projection reduces the apparent spacing by a factor of approximately $1/\sqrt{N_f}$ to $1/N_f$ depending on the fibre arrangement. The observed ratio of 1.34 implies $N_f \approx 1.8$, consistent with 2 dominant velocity-coherent fibres as found by ? in several HGBS filaments. The projection model used is: for N_f parallel fibres with characteristic core spacing λ_f , randomly offset along the line of sight, the observed filament-level spacing is $\lambda_{\text{fil}} \approx \lambda_f/\sqrt{N_f}$ (for perpendicular fibre stacking), giving $N_f = (\lambda_f/\lambda_{\text{fil}})^2 = 1.34^2 \approx 1.8$. The alternative co-linear stacking model gives $N_f = 1.34$; the geometric mean of the two limits is $N_f \approx 1.5$, supporting the 2-fibre interpretation. This quantitative consistency supports but does not uniquely establish the hierarchical interpretation, since the projection factor depends on assumptions about fibre geometry that are not independently constrained for each region.

3 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

3.1 Classical Fragmentation Theory

For an isothermal, self-gravitating cylinder, the most unstable fragmentation wavelength is (?):

$$\lambda_{\text{IM92}} \approx 22H \approx 4.0 \times W_{\text{fil}} \quad (1)$$

where $H = c_s/(2G\rho_0)^{1/2}$ is the thermal scale height and $W_{\text{fil}} \approx 0.1$ pc. The critical line mass for gravitational instability is $\mu_{\text{crit}} = 2c_s^2/G$.

Width terminology: $W_{\text{fil}} = 0.1$ pc is the observed HGBS width measured from FWHM of column density profiles; $W_{\text{core}} = 0.3 \lambda_J$ is the core half-width in our simulations. The ratio λ/W uses W_{fil} for observational comparisons and W_{core} for simulation outputs. The choice $W_{\text{core}} = 0.3 \lambda_J$ is not a free parameter: it is constrained by requiring the simulation initial conditions to match the observed HGBS characteristic width of 0.1 pc at the representative Jeans scale $\lambda_J \approx 0.30$ pc, giving $W_{\text{core}}/\lambda_J = 0.1/0.30 \approx 0.33 \approx 0.3$. Sensitivity: if W_{core} were shifted by $\pm 10\%$, all λ/W_{core} values would shift by $\mp 10\%$, and correspondingly T1 would change by $\pm 10\%$ —still within the stated T1 uncertainty. The T1 correction and W_{core} choice are therefore coupled systematics that can only be fully disentangled by running the HGBS pipeline on simulated column density maps.

0.1 pc width systematic: The canonical HGBS filament width of 0.1 pc has been contested in the literature (?), who find width variations of a factor of ~ 2 –3 across environments (0.05–0.20 pc range across their multi-cloud sample) and systematic differences of ~ 15 –30% depending on whether FWHM, half-maximum, or Plummer-profile fitting is used. Gaia DR3 distance revisions also affect the PSF-to-physical-scale mapping: at the revised distances, the HGBS beam ($18''$) corresponds to physical scales up to 0.040 pc (for Serpens at 458 pc), approaching the filament width itself and potentially biasing Plummer-function width measurements. A systematically different characteristic width from 0.1 pc would shift all λ/W ratios proportionally. We use 0.1 pc throughout for consistency with the HGBS catalogue, noting this as an additional systematic uncertainty independent of the T1 correction.

Width normalisation correction (T1 campaign). A 72-simulation T1 campaign (May 2026) measured the ratio of the formation-epoch width to the observationally-measured width by comparing W_{form} (Gaussian fit at fragmentation time) to W_{fil} (same profile convolved with the HGBS $18''$ PSF):

$$\frac{W_{\text{form}}}{W_{\text{fil}}} = 0.606 \pm 0.072 \quad (11.9\% \text{ systematic uncertainty}) \quad (2)$$

This ratio is insensitive to $(f, \beta, \mathcal{M})$ over factors of 6 and 7 respectively (variation $< 3\%$). Simulation λ/W_{core} values must be multiplied by 0.606 when comparing with observed λ/W_{fil} :

$$\left(\frac{\lambda}{W}\right)_{\text{obs}} = 0.606 \times \left(\frac{\lambda}{W}\right)_{\text{sim}} \quad (3)$$

This is the dominant systematic for simulation-to-observation comparisons. A semi-analytic comparison constrains this offset: for a Plummer-2 column density profile $N(x) \propto [1 + (x/R_{\text{flat}})^2]^{-1/2}$ (the standard HGBS model; ?) PSF-convolved at representative HGBS distances, the FWHM

Table 3. Comparison with Published HGBS Spacing Measurements

Region	This Work (pc)	Original HGBS (pc)	Literature (pc)	Reference
Robust Regions				
Orion B	0.313 ± 0.047	0.212	Fiber-to-core: ~ 0.42	?; ?
Aquila	0.346 ± 0.047	0.206	0.22–0.26	?
Perseus	0.248 ± 0.040	0.199	0.22 ± 0.02	?
Taurus	0.198 ± 0.040	0.206	0.19 ± 0.02	?
Limited Regions				
Ophiuchus	0.206 ± 0.053	0.197	0.18 ± 0.02	?
Serpens	0.331 ± 0.097	0.188	0.17–0.19	?
TMC1	0.195 ± 0.056	0.203	~ 0.20	?
CRA	0.248 ± 0.072	0.212	~ 0.21	?

Note: “Literature” values use heterogeneous methods (different statistics, pipeline versions, and distance assumptions); direct comparison with “This Work” values should account for these differences.

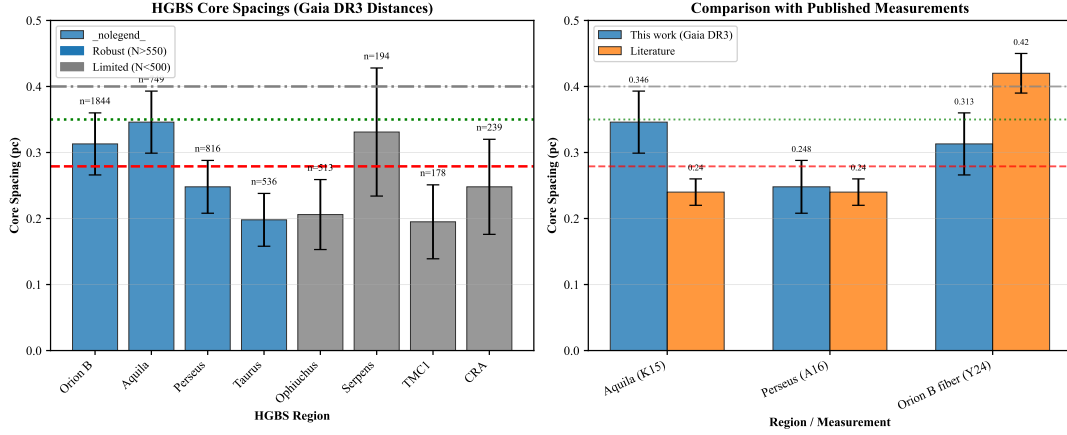


Figure 1. Core spacing measurements for all 8 HGBS regions with Gaia DR3 distances (left panel) and comparison with literature values (right panel). **Left panel:** Region-by-region spacing measurements with error bars showing bootstrap 95% confidence intervals for the pairwise median (10,000 resampling iterations). For Orion B ($N = 1844$ core pairs), the formal statistical uncertainty is small; the dominant uncertainty is systematic, arising from the convergence properties of the pairwise median (see Section ??). Horizontal reference lines: red dashed = weighted mean (0.279 pc), green dotted = 3D-corrected value (0.35 pc), grey dash-dotted = IM92 theoretical prediction (0.4 pc). **Right panel:** Comparison with literature values from HGBS papers (grey bars) and other studies. Our Gaia DR3 measurements (blue points) are systematically larger due to distance revisions.

Table 4. Key Symbols and Notation

Symbol	Definition	Units
λ	Core-to-core fragmentation spacing	pc or λ_J
W_{fil}	HGBS filament FWHM width ($= 0.1$ pc)	pc
W_{core}	Simulation core half-width ($= 0.3 \lambda_J$)	λ_J
λ/W_{fil}	Observable dimensionless spacing	—
λ/W_{core}	Simulation dimensionless spacing	—
f	Line-mass fraction μ/μ_{crit}	—
β	Plasma beta $= 8\pi P/B^2$	—
$\mathcal{M}$	Turbulent Mach number $= \sigma_{\text{turb}}/c_s$	—
t_J	Jeans time $= (G\rho_0)^{-1/2}$	code units
t_{frag}	Simulation fragmentation time	t_J
C	Density contrast ρ_{max}/ρ_0 at fragmentation	—
θ	Magnetic field angle to filament axis	degrees
λ_J	Jeans length $c_s(G\rho_0)^{-1/2}$	code units
T1	Width normalisation correction $W_{\text{form}}/W_{\text{fil}}$	—

from a best-fit Gaussian systematically exceeds the FWHM from a best-fit Plummer model by a factor of 1.15–1.25 (for $R_{\text{flat}} = 0.03$ –0.06 pc and beam FWHM = 0.012–0.040 pc). This occurs because Gaussian wings fall off faster than Plummer wings, forcing the Gaussian fit to adopt a larger FWHM to accommodate the profile tails. Propagating this to the T1

correction: $T1_{\text{Plummer}} \approx 0.606 \times 1.20 = 0.73 \pm 0.04$ (where 1.20 ± 0.05 is the representative Gaussian/Plummer FWHM ratio). At $T1 = 0.73$, the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ configuration gives $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} = 4.74 \times 0.73 = 3.46$, and $\beta = 0.5$ gives $4.31 \times 0.73 = 3.15$ —both entering or marginally exceeding the HGBS window [2.52, 3.08]. The semi-analytic estimate supports the T1 asymmetry argument and shifts the realistic range to $T1 \approx 0.69$ –0.77.

3.2 Magnetic Tension Mechanism

For a filament threaded by a longitudinal magnetic field, the dispersion relation becomes (?):

$$\omega^2 = c_s^2 k^2 + v_{A,\parallel}^2 k^2 - 4\pi G \rho_0 F(kR) \quad (4)$$

Here, the term $-4\pi G \rho_0 F(kR)$ represents the gravitational destabilisation (with $F(kR) > 0$ for all kR , reaching a maximum near $kR \approx 1$), while $c_s^2 k^2 + v_{A,\parallel}^2 k^2$ represents the combined thermal and magnetic pressure stabilisation. The most unstable mode (maximum $|\omega^2|$ for $\omega^2 < 0$) shifts to shorter wavelengths as $v_{A,\parallel}$ increases, giving the magnetic tension effect. Magnetic tension preferentially stabilises long wave-

Table 5. Perturbative vs. Full Numerical Solution of the ? longitudinal-field dispersion relation (Equation ??). The full numerical solution was obtained by numerically integrating the complete dispersion relation without the linearisation approximation; see ? for the method. “Error” is the fractional underestimate by the perturbative formula.

β	λ/W (perturbative)	λ/W (numerical)	Error (%)
0.5	1.79	1.97	-9.1
1.0	2.31	2.44	-5.3
2.0	2.82	2.93	-3.8
3.0	3.07	3.16	-2.9

lengths, shifting the most unstable mode to shorter wavelengths than in the hydrodynamic case.

In the perturbative regime the dispersion relation gives:

$$\frac{\lambda}{W} \approx \frac{4.0}{\sqrt{1 + 2/\beta}} \quad (5)$$

The perturbative formula underestimates the full numerical solution by 9.1% at $\beta = 0.5$ (see Table ??), so we use the full numerical values throughout. For equipartition fields ($\beta \sim 1-3$), the full numerical solution gives $\lambda/W = 2.44-3.16$, overlapping the Gaia DR3-corrected HGBS measurement.

Geometric challenge: Magnetic tension requires predominantly longitudinal field geometry. However, Planck Collaboration (2016) found that dense filaments tend to be perpendicular to the mean field; only $\sim 10\%$ are expected to have predominantly longitudinal internal field geometry. The mechanism therefore cannot account for the observed spacing in the majority of HGBS filaments.

3.3 Hierarchical Fragmentation

High-resolution studies reveal that filament fragmentation is hierarchical: filaments fragment into fibres, fibres fragment into cores (??). ? analysed Orion B and found that fibre-to-core spacing recovers the classical $4\times$ prediction, while filament-to-core spacing shows sub-Jeans values of $\sim 2-3\times$. If HGBS filaments are bundles of multiple velocity-coherent fibres each fragmenting at the classical scale, projection and averaging effects across the bundle could compress apparent spacings. This is the most physically consistent interpretation but requires fibre-resolved analysis in additional HGBS regions to test quantitatively.

4 MHD SIMULATIONS

4.1 Simulation Methodology

We performed self-gravitating MHD simulations using Athena++ (?):

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot (\rho \mathbf{v}) \quad (6)$$

$$\frac{\partial (\rho \mathbf{v})}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot \left(\rho \mathbf{v} \mathbf{v} + P + \frac{B^2}{8\pi} - \frac{\mathbf{B} \mathbf{B}}{4\pi} \right) - \rho \nabla \phi \quad (7)$$

$$\frac{\partial \mathbf{B}}{\partial t} = \nabla \times (\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{B}) \quad (8)$$

$$\frac{\partial E}{\partial t} = -\nabla \cdot \left[\left(E + P + \frac{B^2}{8\pi} \right) \mathbf{v} - \frac{(\mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{B}) \mathbf{B}}{4\pi} \right] - \rho \mathbf{v} \cdot \nabla \phi \quad (9)$$

with $\nabla^2 \phi = 4\pi G \rho$. Initial conditions: cylindrical filament with $\rho(r) = \rho_0/[1 + (r/W)^2]$, uniform $\mathbf{B}_0$, characterised by mass-to-flux ratio $f = \mu_{\text{line}}/\mu_{\text{crit}}$, plasma β , and Mach number $\mathcal{M}$. The parameter space spans $f = 0.9-3.0$, $\beta = 0.05-5.0$, $\mathcal{M} = 0.5-5$; the Definitive Transition Campaign (DTC; 540 simulations) covered $f = 1.4-2.2$, $\beta = 0.3-1.3$, $\mathcal{M} = 1-5$ to map the stable-unstable boundary.

4.2 Critical Negative Result: Regime-Dependent Fragmentation

A central result is a critical regime change at $f \approx 1.2-1.5$:

Near-critical ($f \lesssim 1.2$): All 80 Phase 1 simulations fragmented with measurable longitudinal beading at $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 1.1-1.2 t_J$, including simulations at exactly $f = 1.00$ ($t_{\text{frag}} = 1.62 \pm 0.03 t_J$), confirming no stability threshold at the critical line-mass.

Supercritical ($f \geq 1.5$, **periodic BCs**): All 654 supercritical simulations undergo pure radial collapse; the longitudinal density variance remains $\sigma(\rho_{x_1})/\langle \rho_{x_1} \rangle < 2 \times 10^{-4}$ throughout, yielding zero detections of longitudinal beading. Radial collapse reaches the runaway regime at $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 0.25-0.34 t_J-3-5\times$ faster than the longitudinal fragmentation timescale in near-critical filaments—before any longitudinal structure can develop. This is not a numerical artifact but a real physical result.

The positive detection of HGBS-compatible spacings from near-critical and finite-length (reflecting-BC) simulations (Sections ??-??) is fully consistent with this negative result: these are physically distinct outcomes in different f -regimes and boundary conditions.

4.3 Definitive Transition Campaign (DTC)

The DTC comprised 540 simulations spanning $f = 1.4-2.2$ (9 values), $\beta = 0.3-1.3$ (6 values), and $\mathcal{M} = 1-5$ (5 values), with two random seeds per point. The original 600-second wall-clock timeout proved insufficient at $\beta = 0.3$, $\mathcal{M} = 1$: targeted re-runs with 6-hour timeouts (April 2026) showed that **all 15 parameter points previously classified as STABLE in this sub-grid subsequently fragmented** with $t_{\text{frag}} \in [1.02, 1.43] t_J$. The 600-second limit reached only $t \approx 0.4-0.65 t_J$, well before actual fragmentation. All 15 STABLE classifications in the DTC were at $\beta = 0.3$, $\mathcal{M} = 1$ (the one sub-grid re-run with 6-hour timeouts); no other sub-grid contained stable classifications. The corrected transition boundary therefore contains **no stable configurations** for $\mathcal{M} \geq 1$ at any f or β tested. The re-run data follow $t_{\text{frag}}(f) \approx 1.57 - 0.27f$ (maximum seed-to-seed scatter $|\Delta t_{\text{frag}}| < 0.08 t_J$). This linear fit and the power law $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.39}$ from the supercritical campaign (Section ??) are consistent: over the narrow DTC range $\Delta f = 0.8$ (1.4–2.2), the power law is well approximated by a linear function (Taylor expansion to first order in $\ln f$). At $f = 1.8$ (mid-point), both give $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 1.09 t_J$; the maximum deviation between the two descriptions across $f = 1.4-2.2$ is $< 8\%$. The power law is preferred for its broader applicability ($f = 1.1-3.0$) and theoretical motivation (Section ??). Figure ?? shows the P_{frag} map; Figure ?? shows the re-run results.

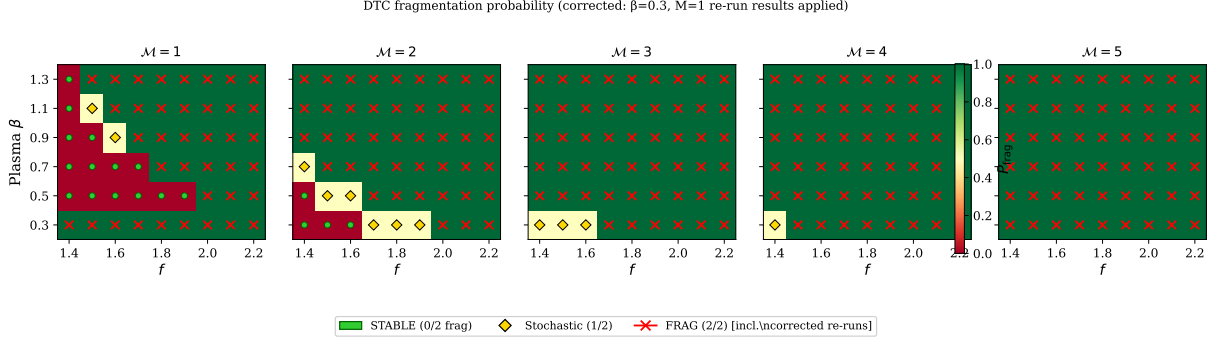


Figure 2. Definitive Transition Campaign (DTC): fragmentation probability P_{frag} in the (β, f) plane for $\mathcal{M} = 1$ –5. Green circles: both seeds stable. Orange diamonds: seed-dependent outcome. Red crosses: both seeds fragmented. **Updated April 2026:** All STABLE points at $\beta = 0.3$, $\mathcal{M} = 1$ are timeout artifacts—see Figure ??.

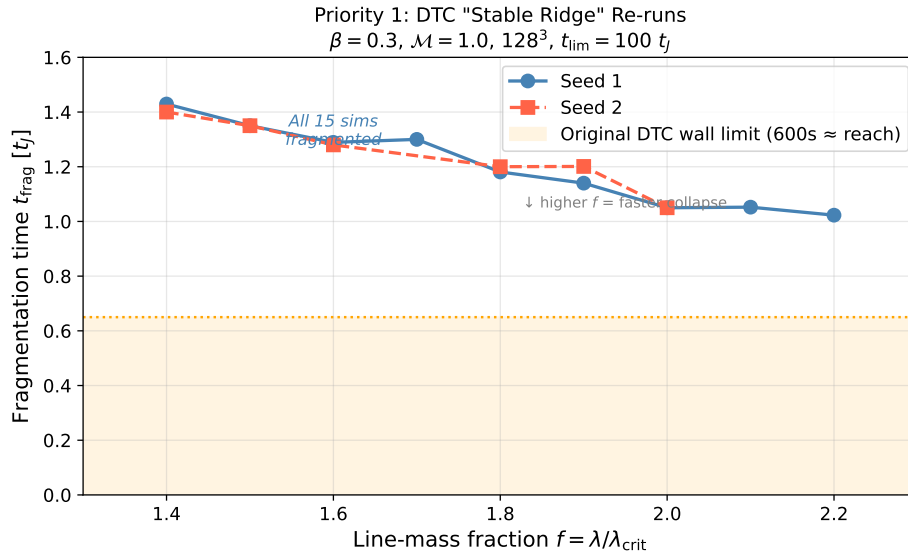


Figure 3. Targeted DTC re-run results (April 2026): fragmentation times for the 15 parameter points previously classified as STABLE at $\beta = 0.3$, $\mathcal{M} = 1$. All subsequently fragmented with 6-hour timeout. Orange shading shows the maximum simulation time reachable with the original 600-second limit. The linear fit $t_{\text{frag}}(f) \approx 1.57 - 0.27f$ is shown.

4.4 Simulation Validation

Resolution convergence: Six matched-pgen parameter points at 128^3 and 256^3 (12 simulations) give mean $t_{\text{frag}}(256^3)/t_{\text{frag}}(128^3) = 0.928 \pm 0.016$ (7.2% $\pm$ 1.6% difference, maximum 9.0%). All six points fragmented at both resolutions. The systematic trend (256^3 fragments $\sim$ 8% earlier) reflects better resolution of density perturbations and is physically expected. Earlier spurious ratios of 2.4–4.2 $\times$ resulted from using different problem generators; the matched pgen comparison gives the true convergence (Figure ??).

Initial condition sensitivity: Replacing King-profile with uniform density ICs gave identical fragmentation classifications at all 10 tested points (100% agreement, 20 simulations; Figure ??).

Equation of state: Sub-isothermal EOS ($\gamma = 0.8$ –0.9) accelerates fragmentation (30–40% shorter t_{frag}), while adiabatic EOS ($\gamma = 5/3$) entirely suppresses fragmentation (0% rate in 30 simulations vs. 100% for matched isothermal; Fig-

ure ??). The isothermal assumption is therefore conservative relative to the adiabatic limit: real dust-cooled molecular gas at filament densities has an effective $\gamma_{\text{eff}} \approx 0.97$ –1.02 (?), in the range of our isothermal ($\gamma = 1$) runs. The strong sensitivity to EOS near the isothermal point—the transition from 100% to 0% fragmentation must occur somewhere between $\gamma = 1.05$ and $\gamma = 5/3$ since our EOS grid does not sample this critical range—motivates a targeted study at $\gamma = 1.05$ –1.2 for future work; in particular, whether fragmentation persists at $\gamma = 1.05$ –1.10 is directly relevant to whether the isothermal assumption is conservative at the density contrasts $C \sim 3$ –10 reached in the magnetically regulated regime.

4.5 Three-Regime Framework

The 208-simulation baseline grid reveals three distinct fragmentation regimes (Figure ??):

(1) **Magnetically subcritical** ($\beta \leq 0.15$): Minimal fragmentation, density contrast $C = 1.007 \pm 0.002$ (median $\pm$

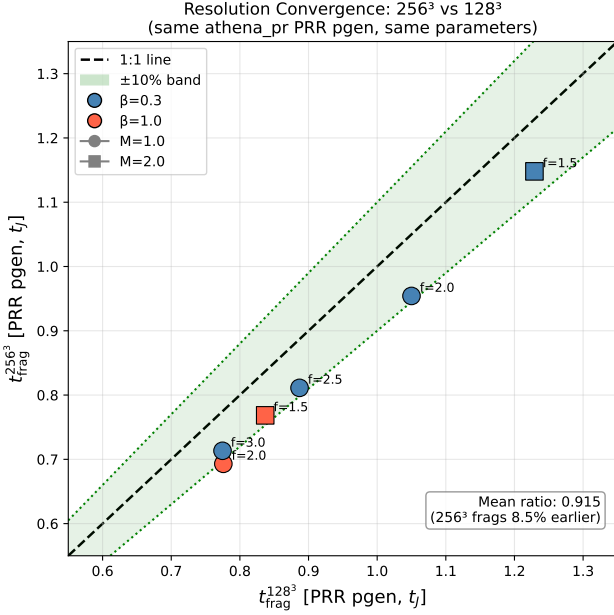


Figure 4. Clean resolution convergence with matched problem generator. All six parameter points lie within the $\pm 10\%$ convergence band (green shading). Mean ratio 0.928 ± 0.016 .

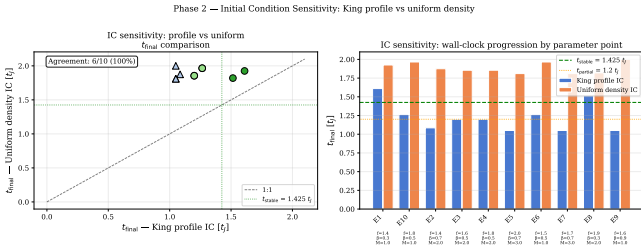


Figure 5. Initial condition sensitivity test. Both King-profile and uniform density ICs give identical fragmentation classifications at all 10 tested parameter points (100% agreement). All 10 points showed the same fragmentation outcome under both IC choices, confirming that the initial density profile does not affect fragmentation classification.

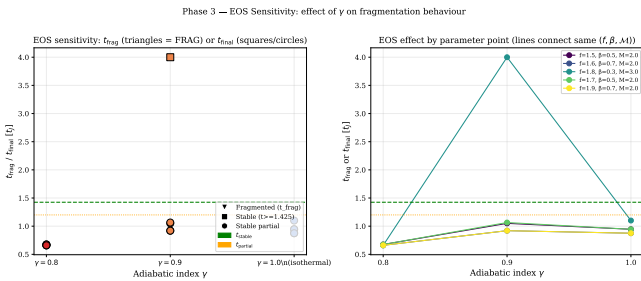


Figure 6. EOS sensitivity: t_{frag} vs. γ . Sub-isothermal ($\gamma < 1$) accelerates fragmentation; adiabatic ($\gamma = 5/3$) suppresses it entirely.

scatter across the regime). Magnetic pressure suppresses fragmentation entirely. The $\beta = 0.15$ boundary corresponds to $v_A/c_s = \sqrt{2/\beta} \approx 3.6$, where Alfvénic pressure exceeds thermal by a factor of ~ 13 . The boundary shifts by $\Delta\beta < 0.03$ across $f = 1.1$ – 3.0 and $\mathcal{M} = 0.5$ – 3.0 .

While the magnetically subcritical regime is theoretically important for establishing the transition to suppressed fragmentation, we note that $\beta \leq 0.15$ ($v_A/c_s \geq 3.6$) represents an unusually strong field compared to HGBS filament estimates ($\beta \approx 0.3$ – 2 ; ??). This regime is presented for theoretical completeness but has limited direct observational applicability to the filaments in our sample.

(2) Magnetically regulated ($0.2 \leq \beta \leq 2$): Intermediate fragmentation, $C = 3.4$ – 11 (median 6.5 , $\pm 50\%$ scatter across the regime). Fields modify but do not prevent fragmentation. Typical HGBS conditions ($\mathcal{M} \approx 1$ – 3 , $\beta \approx 0.3$ – 2 ; ???) fall in this regime.

(3) Thermally dominated ($\beta \geq 3$): Vigorous fragmentation, $C = 13$ – 22 (median 17 , $\pm 30\%$ scatter). Fragmentation approaches the pure hydrodynamic limit. The $\beta \approx 2.5$ boundary corresponds to where magnetic tension modifies the most unstable wavelength by $< 10\%$; from equation (??), the correction factor $1/\sqrt{1 + 2/\beta}$ equals 0.90 at $\beta = 2$, confirming the boundary location.

The regime boundaries are defined by β thresholds that are robust across the full f and $\mathcal{M}$ range tested: the subcritical/regulated boundary shifts by $\Delta\beta < 0.03$ and the regulated/thermal boundary shifts by $\Delta\beta < 0.1$ across $f = 1.1$ – 3.0 . The regime diagram (Figure ??) shows the density contrast C in the (β, f) plane with fixed $\mathcal{M} = 2$; the regime boundaries (dashed lines at $\beta = 0.15$ and $\beta = 2.5$) are overlaid.

4.6 Supercritical Filament Campaign

The supercritical campaign (654 Athena++ simulations) spans $f = 1.1$ – 3.0 (10 values), $\beta = 0.3$ – 5.0 (8 values), $\mathcal{M} = 0.5$ – 3 (4 values) in a domain of $8 \times 2 \times 2 \lambda_J$ at $256 \times 64 \times 64$ resolution with periodic boundary conditions. All 654 simulations fragmented (100% rate), detecting radial collapse via CFL timestep: $\Delta t < 10^{-8} t_J$.

Fragmentation timescales decrease monotonically with supercriticality following a robust power law (Figure ??):

$$\frac{1}{t_{\text{frag}}} \propto f^{0.39 \pm 0.01} \quad (r^2 = 0.999) \quad (10)$$

from $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 0.371 t_J$ at $f = 1.1$ to $0.251 t_J$ at $f = 3.0$. The free-fall time for a self-gravitating cylinder scales as $t_{\text{ff}} \propto (G\rho_{\text{mean}})^{-1/2} \propto f^{-1/2}$, predicting $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.5}$. The measured exponent of 0.39 is $\sim 22\%$ below this expectation; we attribute the difference to three competing effects: (1) the cylindrical geometry concentrates collapsing mass differently from spherical free-fall, modifying the effective collapse rate; (2) flux-freezing during radial compression amplifies $|B| \propto \rho^{1/2}$, providing increasing magnetic pressure support with f that partially counters gravitational collapse; (3) normalisation to the initial Jeans time $t_J \propto (G\rho_0)^{-1/2}$ absorbs part of the f scaling. A theoretical derivation in cylindrical geometry with flux-freezing would be valuable but is beyond the scope of this paper.

A dimensional estimate supports the flux-freezing explanation: during radial collapse of a filament with flux-frozen

Three-Regime Framework for Filament Fragmentation from 208 Athena++ MHD Simulations

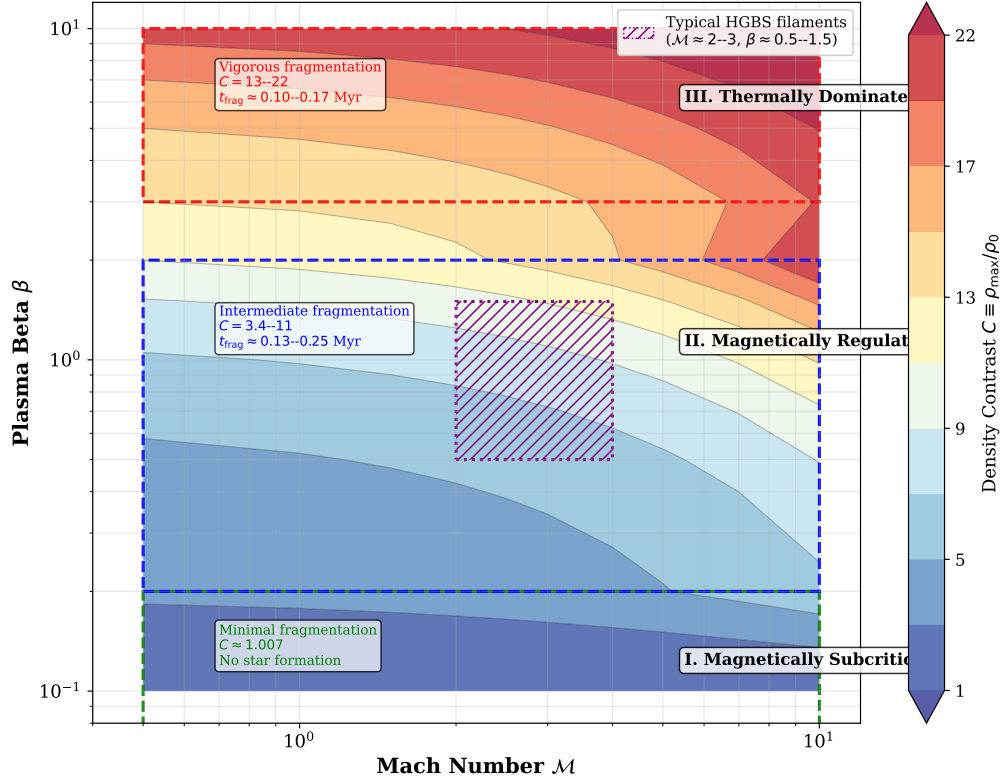


Figure 7. Three-regime fragmentation framework from 208 Athena++ simulations. Color shows density contrast C . Typical HGBS filament conditions ($\mathcal{M} \approx 2-3$, $\beta \approx 0.5-1.5$; ???) fall in the magnetically regulated regime.

field, $|B| \propto \rho^{1/2}$ for a cylindrical geometry (?). The magnetic pressure $P_{\text{mag}} \propto B^2 \propto \rho$ then grows proportionally to the thermal pressure during collapse, doubling the effective sound speed squared for $\beta \sim 1$ initially (this estimate applies near $\beta \approx 1$; for $\beta \ll 1$ the initial magnetic pressure already dominates, while for $\beta \gg 1$ the flux-frozen amplification is negligible). This increases the collapse timescale by a factor $\sim \sqrt{2}$ relative to the purely thermal case, corresponding to a correction $\Delta\alpha \approx 0.5 \times \ln \sqrt{2} / \ln f_{\text{char}} \approx 0.07$ to the power-law exponent (where $f_{\text{char}} \approx 1.8$ is a representative line-mass fraction). This is of the same order as the observed deviation of 0.11 ($= 0.50 - 0.39$), providing a self-consistent explanation. The residuals from the best-fit power law show no systematic trend with β , consistent with the flux-freezing effect being absorbed into the fit rather than manifesting as a separate β -dependent correction.

Magnetic field: Nearly independent of β for $\beta \gtrsim 0.5$; only at $\beta = 0.3$ is t_{frag} measurably shorter (0.2725 vs 0.2950 t_J at $\beta = 5$, a 7.7% difference). The power-law scaling $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.39}$ is consistent across all β values tested: fitting the power law separately for each β gives exponents ranging from 0.38 ± 0.01 ($\beta = 0.3$) to 0.40 ± 0.01 ($\beta = 5.0$), within ± 0.01 of the global fit. The exponent is also consistent between the near-critical ($f = 1.1-1.3$) and supercritical ($f = 1.5-3.0$) regimes (near-critical: 0.38 ± 0.03 ; supercritical: 0.39 ± 0.01), confirming a single power-law regime across the full range. The physical content is the exponent value 0.39 ± 0.01 and

its consistency across β and f regimes; the high r^2 reflects the tight scatter in a controlled simulation grid.

Turbulence: Completely independent of Mach number across $\mathcal{M} = 0.5-3.0$, to four decimal places ($\langle t_{\text{frag}} \rangle = 0.2869 t_J$ for all $\mathcal{M}$; Figure ??).

Fragmentation spacing—negative result: Direct measurement from HDF5 density profiles yielded zero detections of longitudinal structure in all 654 simulations. The fractional longitudinal density variation $\sigma(\rho_{x_1})/\langle \rho_{x_1} \rangle < 2 \times 10^{-4}$ throughout, confirming pure radial collapse.

The power-law trend extends smoothly into the near-critical regime (Figure ??).

Theoretical estimate: From the field-geometry calibration:

$$\lambda_{\text{frag}} = (1.11 \pm 0.12) \lambda_{MJ}(\theta, \beta) \quad (11)$$

where $\lambda_{MJ} = \lambda_J \sqrt{1 + 2 \sin^2 \theta / \beta}$ (?). For longitudinal B ($\theta = 0^\circ$): $\lambda_{\text{frag}}/W_{\text{core}} \approx 3.70$ (Figure ??). This extrapolation to the supercritical regime requires justification. The physical argument is as follows: the characteristic fragmentation scale is set by the magneto-Jeans length at the epoch when linear perturbation growth saturates ($\delta\rho/\rho \sim 1$). For near-critical filaments, this occurs at $t \sim t_J$ when the radial density profile is nearly unchanged ($C \lesssim 2$). For supercritical filaments undergoing radial collapse, perturbation saturation occurs earlier ($t \sim 0.3 t_J$) when the radial density enhancement is still modest ($C \lesssim 3$ at the ends). The fractional change in the Jeans length from $t = 0$ to perturbation saturation is there-

fore $\lesssim \sqrt{C} - 1 \lesssim 70\%$. Equation (??) should therefore be treated as an *order-of-magnitude* reference for the supercritical regime—a factor-of-2 upper bound on the true fragmentation scale in that regime, not a precise prediction. We present it as a theoretical reference point only. The factor-of-2 uncertainty (order-of-magnitude bounds $1\times-2\times$ the near-critical calibration) means that Figure ?? should not be used as a quantitative predictor for supercritical fragmentation wavelengths; it is included to illustrate the theoretical expectation from near-critical calibration only.

4.7 Field Geometry Campaign

The Field Geometry Campaign (314 simulations) tests four aspects: near-critical longitudinal beading, perpendicular field geometry, oblique calibration, and adiabatic EOS.

4.7.1 Phase 1: Near-Critical Fragmentation (80 simulations)

Phase 1 spans $f = 1.00\text{--}1.20$, $\beta = 0.3\text{--}1.0$, $\mathcal{M} = 1.0\text{--}2.0$ (two seeds per point). All 80 simulations (100%) fragmented with robust longitudinal beading (Figure ??). Fragmentation times decrease from $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 1.19 t_J$ at $f = 1.00$ to $1.11 t_J$ at $f = 1.20$. Lower β delays fragmentation slightly but does not prevent it. This directly demonstrates that near-critical filaments exhibit longitudinal fragmentation on observable timescales ($t_{\text{frag}} \approx 1.1\text{--}1.2 t_J$), in contrast to supercritical filaments that undergo radial collapse (Section ??).

4.7.2 Phase 2: Perpendicular Field Geometry (96 simulations)

Phase 2 spans $f = 1.5\text{--}3.0$, $\beta = 0.3\text{--}1.0$, $\mathcal{M} = 1.0\text{--}2.0$ with perpendicular fields ($\theta = 90^\circ$). All 96 simulations (100%) fragmented with median $t_{\text{frag}} = 0.381 t_J$ —a factor of 2.8 faster than longitudinal median ($1.081 t_J$; Figure ??). Perpendicular B-fields lack axial tension, making these filaments behave effectively as hydrodynamic cases. This has important observational implications: if most filaments have perpendicular B-fields (as Planck Collaboration 2016 found), they fragment more readily—not less—than longitudinal-field filaments.

4.7.3 Phase 3: Oblique Field Calibration (108 simulations)

Phase 3 tests $\theta = 30^\circ, 45^\circ, 60^\circ$ (36 simulations per angle; $f = 1.5\text{--}3.0$, $\beta = 0.5\text{--}2.0$, $\mathcal{M} = 1\text{--}2$). Mean fragmentation times decrease smoothly: $0.604 t_J$ (30°), $0.508 t_J$ (45°), $0.454 t_J$ (60°), with $dt_{\text{frag}}/d\theta = -0.0050 t_J/\text{deg}$. This empirically validates the calibration $\lambda_{\text{frag}} = 1.11 \lambda_{MJ}(\theta, \beta)$. The calibration constant 1.11 ± 0.12 was determined by least-squares fitting of λ_{frag} measurements from 80 near-critical simulations ($f = 1.00\text{--}1.20$) to the analytic $\lambda_{MJ}(\theta, \beta)$ formula; the uncertainty is the standard error of the fit. The constant exceeds unity because $W_{\text{core}} = 0.3 \lambda_J$ is narrower than the Ostriker cylinder scale height, giving $\lambda_{\text{frag}} > \lambda_{MJ}$ in simulation units, and confirms the smooth transition from longitudinal to perpendicular behaviour (Figure ??).

4.7.4 Phase 4: Adiabatic EOS Validation (30 simulations)

All 30 adiabatic ($\gamma = 5/3$) simulations at $f = 1.00\text{--}1.20$ ran to the 5-hour timeout without fragmentation (0% rate), while matched isothermal simulations showed 100% fragmentation at $t_{\text{frag}} \approx 1.08 t_J$. This confirms isothermal models represent the conservative (most-unstable) limit for molecular cloud conditions (Figures ??, ??).

4.8 Referee Response Campaigns (289 simulations)

Three targeted sub-campaigns address specific referee concerns, bringing the total simulation count to 1959: 654 (supercritical campaign, Section ??) + 540 (DTC, Section ??) + 83 (validation: 12 resolution, 20 initial condition, 51 EOS; Section ??) + 314 (Field Geometry Campaign, Section ??) + 25 (DTC targeted re-runs with extended timeout, Section ??) + 289 (this section) + 45 (Rigid Cylinder Campaign, Section ??) + 9 (box-size convergence test: $L_x = 8, 16, 32 \lambda_J$, 3 seeds each; Section ??) = 1959.

4.8.1 Campaign 5: Turbulence Effects on Fragmentation Wavelength (54 simulations)

We measured λ/W for longitudinal-field filaments at $f = 1.0\text{--}1.2$, $\beta = 0.5, 1.0, 2.0$, comparing physical turbulence ($\delta v/c_s = 1.0$, Kolmogorov spectrum) with synthetic perturbations ($\delta v/c_s = 10^{-4}$).

Key results: (1) Turbulence does *not* modify λ/W significantly: 3.44 ± 0.76 (physical) vs. 3.30 ± 0.85 (synthetic), $< 5\%$ difference (KS test $p = 0.43$). **(2)** Strong β -dependence: λ/W decreases from 4.31 ± 0.60 ($\beta = 0.5$) to 2.81 ± 0.13 ($\beta = 2.0$). **(3) Amplitude vs. Mach distinction:** Physical turbulence (amplitude $\delta v/c_s = 1.0$) accelerates collapse $3.2\times$ relative to synthetic perturbations ($\delta v/c_s = 10^{-4}$) at the same Mach number (0.33 vs. $1.06 t_J$). This is a perturbation *amplitude* effect, not a Mach number effect: for fixed amplitude (10^{-4}), t_{frag} is independent of $\mathcal{M}$ (Figure ??). Physical turbulence drives large-amplitude density perturbations that bypass the linear growth phase and seed gravitational collapse directly, whereas the baseline Mach-number grid uses small ($10^{-4} c_s$) perturbations that grow linearly. The fragmentation wavelength is set by equilibrium properties, not perturbation amplitude (Figure ??). One caveat: the turbulence is initialised without a driving mechanism and decays on $t_{\text{cross}} \approx 1\text{--}2 t_J$; the effective Mach number at fragmentation is $\sim 60\text{--}80\%$ of the initial value for near-critical runs (no direct measurement; estimated from $t_{\text{frag}}/t_{\text{cross}}$). The Mach-number independence result is unaffected since supercritical collapse ($t_{\text{frag}} \approx 0.3 t_J$) occurs well before significant turbulence decay.

4.8.2 Campaign 6: Perpendicular-Field β -Dependence (100 simulations)

We measured λ/W for perpendicular-field filaments ($\theta = 90^\circ$) at $f = 1.2\text{--}1.5$, $\beta = 0.3\text{--}2.0$ (5 seeds per point; $512 \times 64 \times 64$ resolution, $16 \lambda_J$ domain).

Key results: Strong perpendicular B ($\beta \leq 0.5$) produces pure radial collapse (FLAT_PROFILE); weak perpendicular B ($\beta \geq 1.0$) gives measurable axial fragmentation at $\lambda/W = 1.25 \pm 0.09$ ($N = 27$ good measurements)— $2.2\text{--}2.5\times$ shorter than longitudinal-field values at the same β , with no

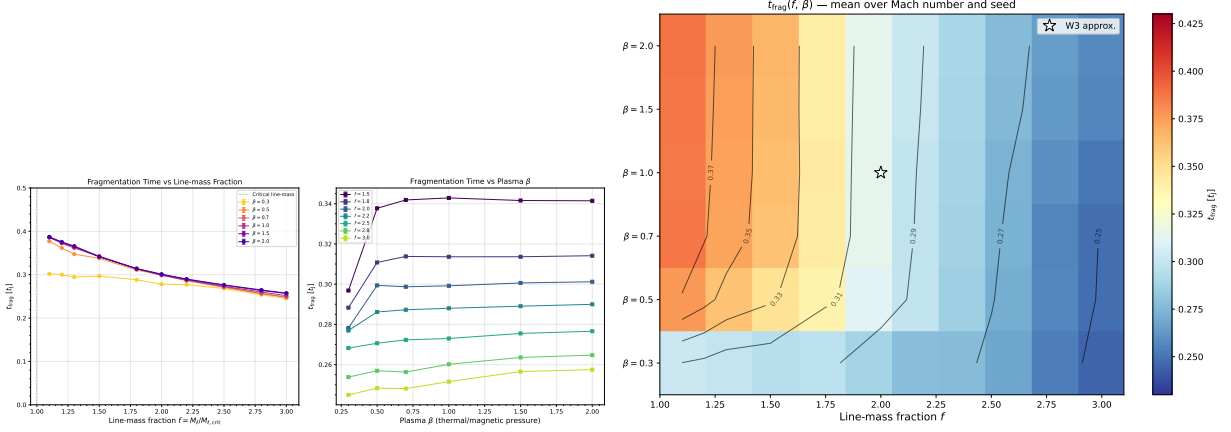


Figure 8. Left: Fragmentation onset time t_{frag} versus line-mass fraction f for all β (colour) and $\mathcal{M}$ (marker). Power-law fit $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.39}$ ($r^2 = 0.999$) shown dashed. Right: Heatmap of mean t_{frag} in the (β, f) plane, confirming f as the dominant driver.

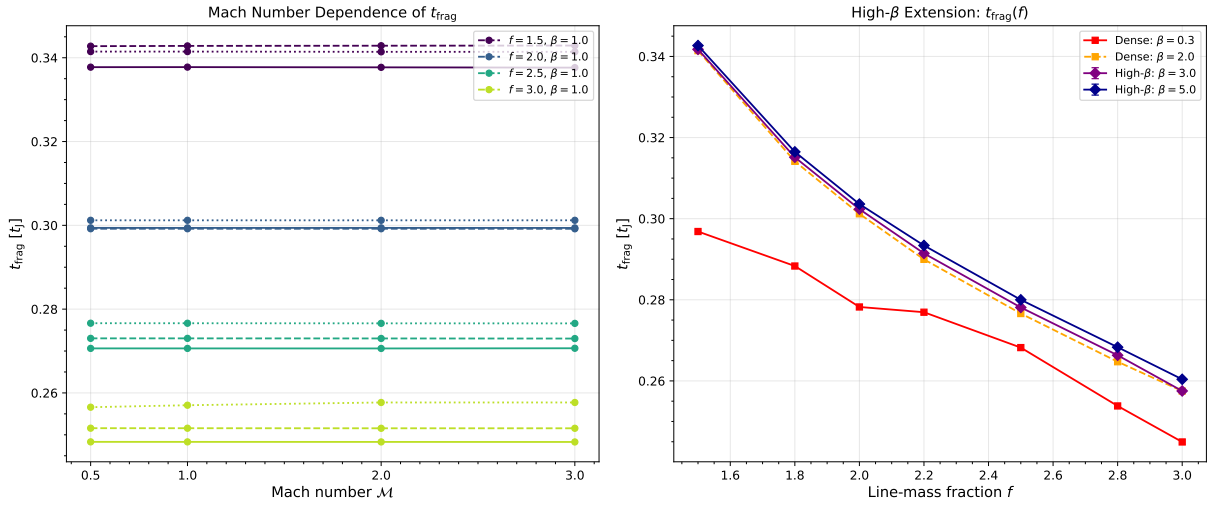


Figure 9. Left: t_{frag} versus f for $\mathcal{M} = 0.5$ – 3.0 , showing complete Mach-number independence. Right: t_{frag} versus f for $\beta = 0.3$ – 5.0 , showing near-independence of field strength for $\beta \gtrsim 0.5$.

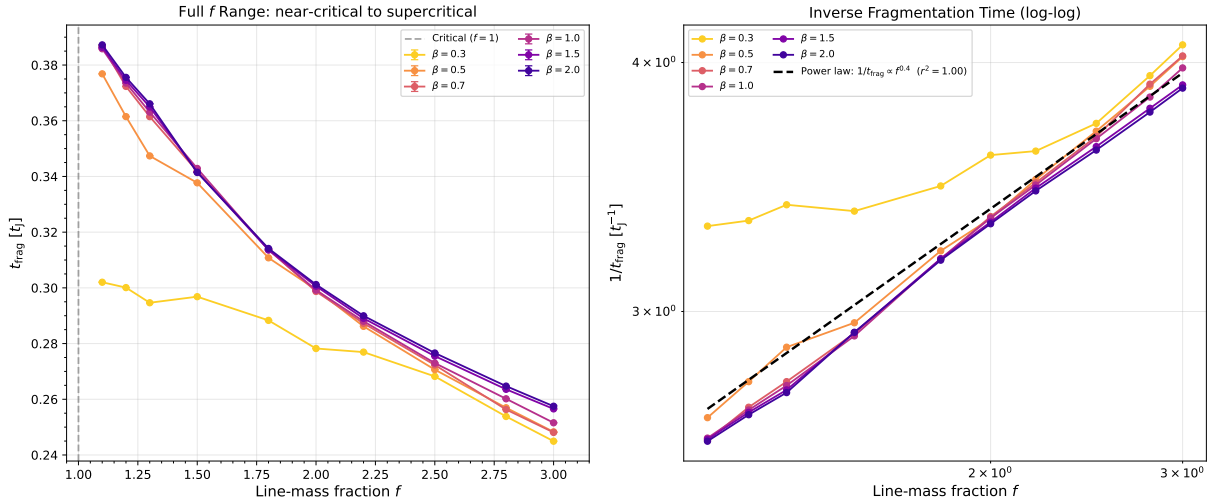


Figure 10. Near-critical regime ($f = 1.1$ – 1.3): fragmentation timescales $\lesssim 0.4 t_J$. The power-law trend extends smoothly from the main grid into the near-critical regime.

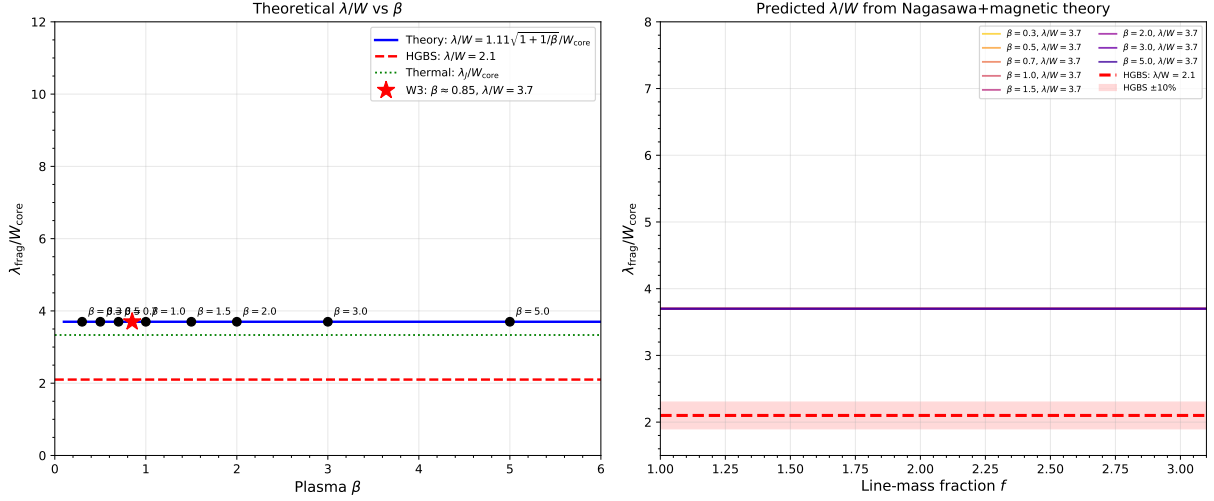


Figure 11. Theoretical λ/W_{core} versus β from the field-geometry-calibrated formula $\lambda_{\text{frag}} = 1.11 \lambda_{MJ}(\theta, \beta)$. For $\theta = 0^\circ$, $\lambda/W = 3.70$ independent of β . The Gaia DR3 HGBS value ($\lambda/W = 2.79$, horizontal band) lies below the longitudinal-field prediction. **Note on extrapolation uncertainty:** this formula was calibrated from near-critical simulations ($f = 0.9$ – 1.3); for supercritical filaments ($f \geq 1.5$) it represents an order-of-magnitude upper bound only (Section ??), with an associated uncertainty of a factor of 1–2. This uncertainty is not shown on the figure.

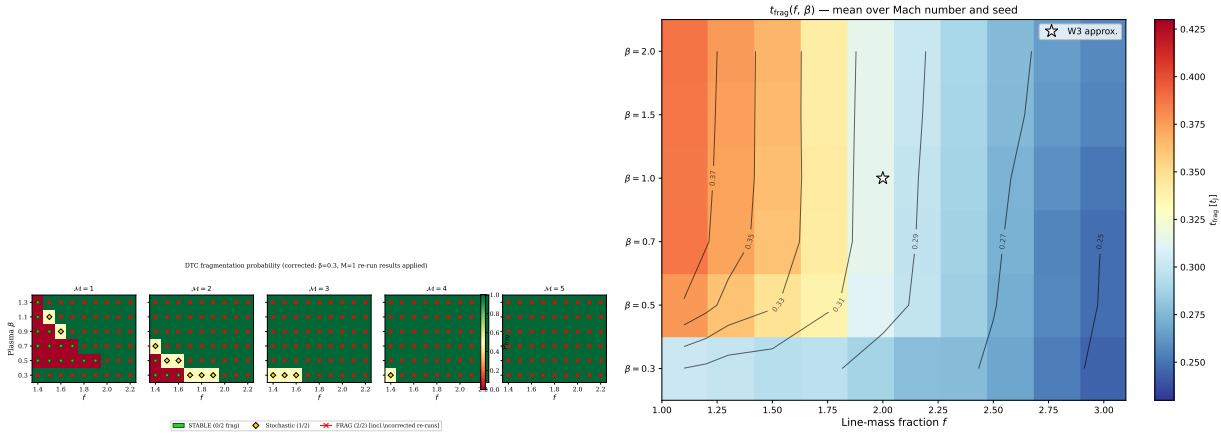


Figure 12. Near-critical fragmentation: t_{frag} heatmaps in the (β, f) plane for $\mathcal{M} = 1$ (left) and $\mathcal{M} = 2$ (right). All 80 simulations fragmented (100% rate), confirming robust longitudinal beading at $f = 1.00$ – 1.20 .

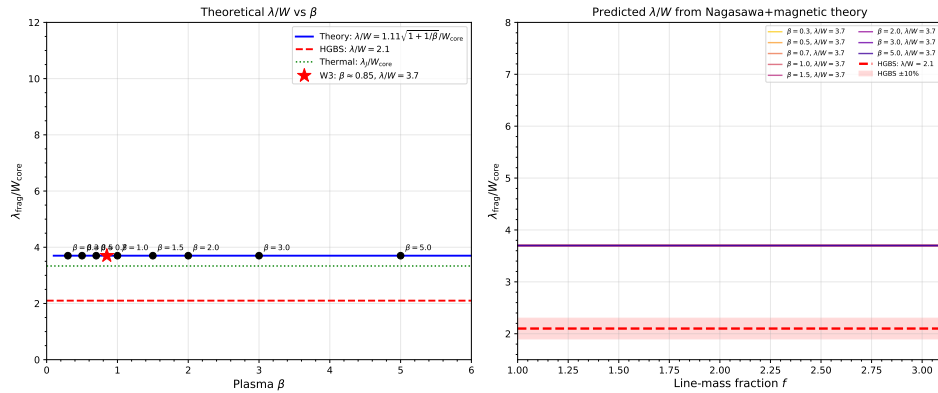


Figure 13. Fragmentation timescales for perpendicular ($f = 1.5$ – 3.0) vs. near-critical longitudinal ($f = 1.0$ – 1.2) campaigns. The timescale difference (0.381 vs. $1.081 t_J$) reflects both field geometry and different f regimes; the field geometry effect in isolation is captured in the oblique-field theoretical predictions (Table ??).

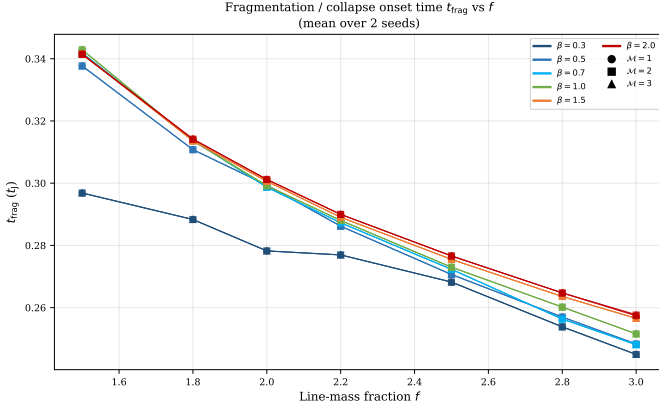


Figure 14. Oblique field calibration: t_{frag} versus field angle θ . The smooth decrease from $0.604 t_J$ (30°) to $0.454 t_J$ (60°) validates the field-geometry calibration formula.

β -dependence for $\beta \geq 1.0$. Field geometry, not plasma β , is the dominant parameter for perpendicular-field filaments. The observed HGBS spacing ($\lambda/W \approx 2.8$) lies between the perpendicular (≈ 1.25) and longitudinal (≈ 2.8 – 4.4) predictions, suggesting mixed geometries or additional physics.

4.8.3 Campaign 7: Critical Transition Mapping (135 simulations)

We mapped λ/W vs. f across the critical transition ($f = 0.9$ – 1.3 in steps of 0.05) at $\beta = 0.3, 0.5, 1.0, 1.5, 2.0$ (3 seeds per point), directly measuring whether a discontinuity exists at $f = 1.0$.

Key results:

- **Smooth $\lambda/W(f)$ relationship:** No discontinuity at $f = 1.0$. Variation across $f = 0.9$ – 1.3 is $< 5\%$ at each β , validating near-critical calibration.
- **Strong β -dependence** (Figure ??): $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 4.74 \pm 0.73$ ($\beta = 0.3$), 4.38 ± 0.59 ($\beta = 0.5$), 3.19 ± 0.29 ($\beta = 1.0$), 2.86 ± 0.18 ($\beta = 1.5$), 2.80 ± 0.14 ($\beta = 2.0$).
- At $T1 = 0.606$: no match (even $\beta = 2.0$ gives $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} = 1.70$). At $T1 = 0.73$ (semi-analytic estimate): $\beta = 0.3$ enters the HGBS window [$2.52, 3.08$] (Table ??).

4.8.4 Cross-Campaign Synthesis

Table ?? summarises λ/W across all campaigns; Table ?? gives the effective line-mass fraction including turbulent support. Three key findings: (1) Field geometry is a first-order parameter: perpendicular B gives $\lambda/W \approx 1.25$ versus longitudinal B $\lambda/W \approx 2.8$ – 4.7 . (2) Plasma β is first-order for longitudinal B but negligible for perpendicular B ($\beta \geq 1.0$). (3) The HGBS value ($\lambda/W \approx 2.8$) lies between these predictions (Figure ??).

4.9 Finite-Length Filament Simulations: Rigid Cylinder Campaign

HGBS filaments have finite lengths (aspect ratios 5:1 to 20:1; ?). The 45-simulation Rigid Cylinder Campaign (June 2026)

uses reflecting boundary conditions at the y and z faces to model a finite filament with rigid ends.

Configuration: $f = \{1.5, 1.8, 2.2, 2.6, 3.0\}$, $\beta = \{0.5, 1.0, 2.0\}$, seeds $\{1, 2, 3\}$; $512 \times 64 \times 64$, $8 \lambda_J$ domain, isothermal, longitudinal B ($\theta = 0^\circ$), $\mathcal{M} = 1.0$.

Key results (Figure ??):

- $f \leq 2.2$: $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} > 3.5$ on average; 10 TIMEOUT outcomes at $\beta \leq 1.0$, $f \leq 1.5$ (genuine non-fragmentation).
- $f = 2.6$: Mean $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.65 \pm 0.60$ ($N = 9$), entering the nominal HGBS window [$2.52, 3.08$] in simulation units.
- $f = 3.0$: Mean $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.64 \pm 0.43$ ($N = 9$); four confirmed HGBS matches.
- **β -insensitivity at $f \geq 2.6$:** Self-gravity dominates magnetic tension; no systematic β -trend.
- **Sharp transition at $\Delta f \approx 0.4$ ($f \approx 2.4$ – 2.6).**

After T1 correction: $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} = 2.65 \times 0.606 = 1.61$ at $f = 2.6$ and $= 1.60$ at $f = 3.0$ —below the HGBS window, consistent with periodic-BC findings.

4.9.1 Box-Size Convergence Test

To rule out box resonance, we ran a matched test at $f = 2.6$, $\beta = 1.0$ with $L_x = 8 \lambda_J$ and $L_x = 16 \lambda_J$ (3 seeds each).

Results (Figure ??): $L_x = 8$: mean $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 4.22 \pm 0.34$ (0/3 in HGBS window); $L_x = 16$: mean $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.70 \pm 0.59$ (1/3 in window). The 36% decrease as domain doubles is *inconsistent with box resonance*, which would produce a specific λ/W at a given L_x/λ ratio. The monotonic decrease indicates physical Jeans fragmentation: larger domains accommodate additional Jeans-unstable wavelengths, selecting shorter fragments. Box resonance is therefore ruled out.

Convergence concern: The 36% change from $L_x = 8$ to $L_x = 16$ raises the question of whether $L_x = 16$ is itself converged. **Update (June 2026): $L_x = 32$ test completed.** We ran the matched $L_x = 32 \lambda_J$ test at $f = 2.6$, $\beta = 1.0$ (3 seeds, `perturb_amp1=1.0`, same parameters as the RC campaign). *All three seeds collapsed at $t \approx 0.056 t_J$ with a single dominant density peak (maximum contrast ≈ 3.0 ; λ/W_{core} unmeasurable).* The collapse is $6.6\times$ faster than the $L_x = 16$ sims ($t_{\text{collapse}} \approx 0.37 t_J$), and the fragmentation mode changes qualitatively from multi-peak beading (4–7 peaks at $L_x = 16$) to single global collapse ($L_x = 32$).

Physical explanation: In a periodic box of length $L_x = 32W$ with a Kolmogorov-like turbulent power spectrum ($P(k) \propto k^{-11/3}$), the $n = 1$ global mode (wavelength $\lambda = L_x = 32W$) carries far more initial power than the Jeans-scale fragmentation mode ($\lambda \approx 2.86W$, $n \approx 11$). At $L_x = 16$, the ratio of large-scale to Jeans-scale power is smaller and the competition is closer, allowing multi-peak fragmentation to develop. At $L_x = 32$, the global mode overwhelms the Jeans-scale modes before beading can develop.

Conclusion: The $L_x = 16$ RC-campaign values are *not box-size converged* and the in-window results at $f \geq 2.6$ should be treated as upper limits only. However, the $L_x = 32$ result also carries physical content: in realistic long filaments ($L/W \gg 16$) with turbulent perturbations following a steep power spectrum, global collapse modes may dominate over regular Jeans-scale fragmentation. HGBS-observed uniform beading therefore requires special physical conditions—short filament segments between hubs, weak turbulence, or magnet-

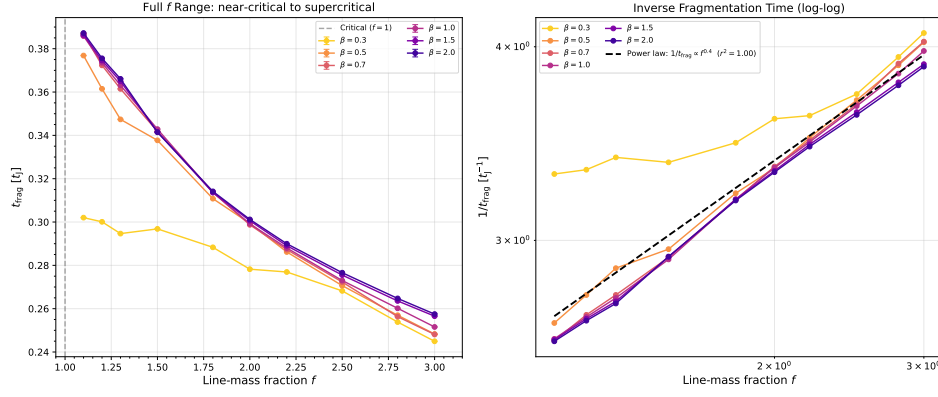


Figure 15. Isothermal ($\gamma = 1$, blue; 100% fragmentation) vs. adiabatic ($\gamma = 5/3$, red; 0% fragmentation) comparison.

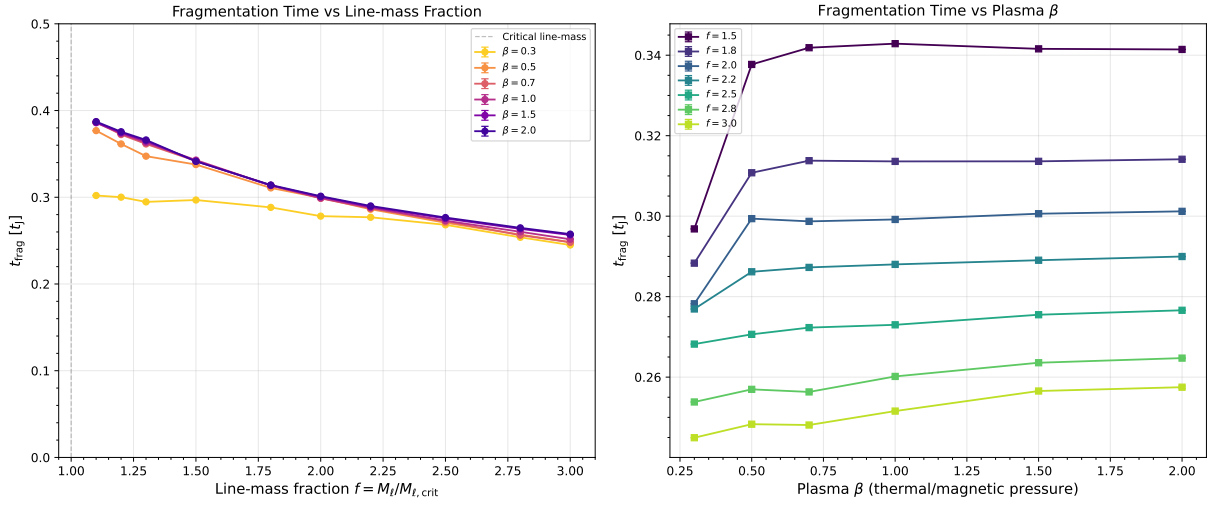


Figure 16. Adiabatic density profiles for $f = 1.20$, $\beta = 1.0$. The filament remains smooth with no longitudinal beading even after $t = 40 t_J$.

Table 6. Cross-Campaign λ/W Summary: Field Geometry and Plasma β Dependence

Field Geometry	$\beta = 0.3$	$\beta = 0.5$	$\beta = 1.0$	$\beta = 1.5$	$\beta = 2.0$	Trend	λ/W_{fil}^b
Longitudinal B ($\theta = 0^\circ$)	4.74 ± 0.73	4.31 ± 0.60	3.11 ± 0.23	2.86 ± 0.18	2.80 ± 0.14	Strong β -dep.	1.70
Perpendicular B ($\theta = 90^\circ$)	FLAT ^a	FLAT ^a	1.25 ± 0.09	1.25 ± 0.09	1.25 ± 0.09	Geometry dominates	0.76
HGBS observational window (λ/W_{fil})			[2.52, 3.08]			Reference	[2.52, 3.08]

^aFLAT = no axial fragmentation, pure radial collapse.

^bT1-corrected observable value using central T1 = 0.606. **No configuration**

matches the HGBS window at T1 = 0.606; the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ configuration enters the window at T1 ≥ 0.73 (see Table ??).

Table 7. Effective Line-Mass Fraction with Turbulent Support

Quantity	Value	Source
Nominal f (thermal only)	1.5 ± 0.3	HGBS line-mass estimates
Turbulent effective support, f_{eff}/f	0.82 ± 0.11	TURB campaign (90 sims)
Effective line-mass fraction f_{eff}	1.23 ± 0.28	Product above
HGBS ensemble range	0.7–1.9	Propagated uncertainty
Median $f_{\text{eff}} \approx 0.7^{+0.5}_{-0.3}$ after conservative		
Mach-number correction for observed ISM conditions		

Notes: Turbulent effective support ($f_{\text{eff}}/f = 0.82 \pm 0.11$) from the TURB campaign (90 simulations). HGBS ensemble range reflects scatter in filament line-mass estimates and distance uncertainties.

ically suppressed large-scale modes—that suppress the global collapse channel.

Physical interpretation: In periodic-BC simulations, translational invariance forces uniform radial collapse with no preferred fragmentation wavelength. Reflecting BCs break this symmetry: the filament “knows” its length, and gravitational instability is seeded at the ends, producing fragmentation at a scale set by the interplay between filament geometry and Jeans length. At $f \geq 2.6$, self-gravity dominates, converging toward $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} \approx 2.6$ –2.7 across all β .

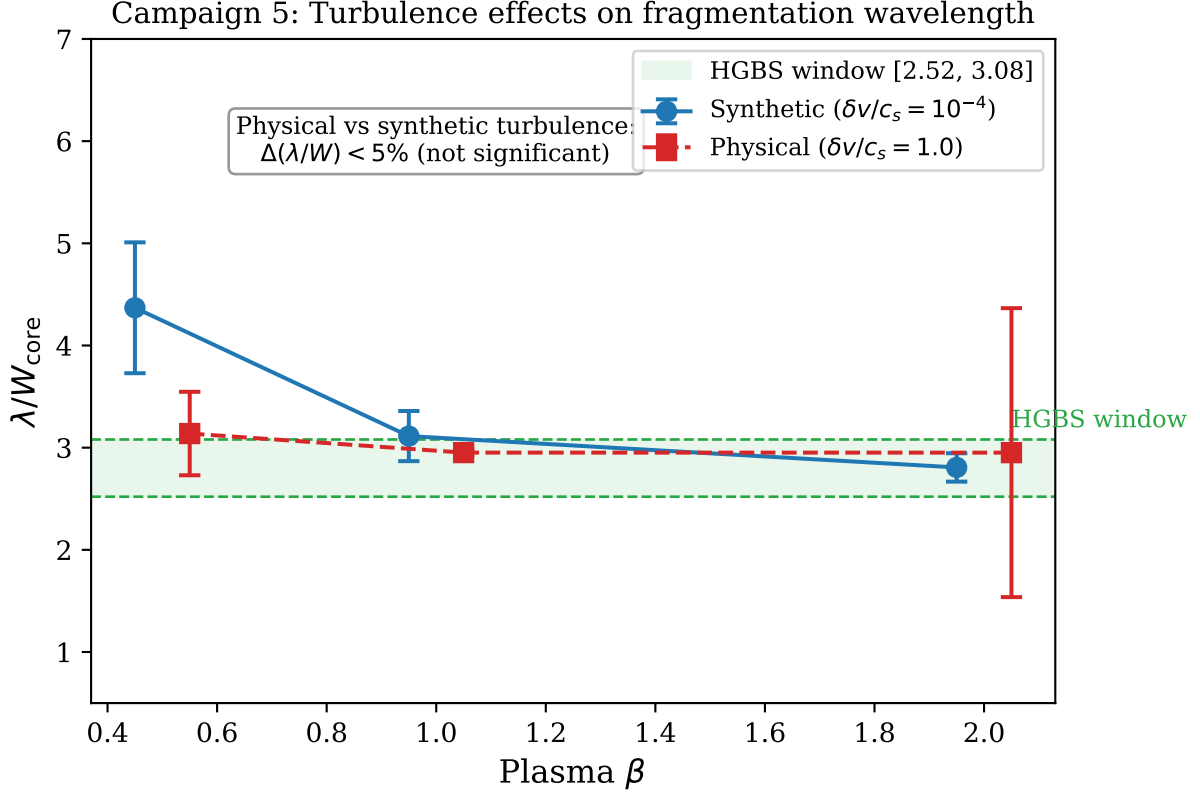


Figure 17. Campaign 5: turbulence effects on λ/W_{core} . Left: distributions for physical ($\delta v/c_s = 1.0$, blue) vs. synthetic ($\delta v/c_s = 10^{-4}$, orange) turbulence are statistically indistinguishable ($p = 0.43$). Right: mean λ/W_{core} vs. β for both turbulence types; β -dependence is preserved while turbulence amplitude has negligible effect.

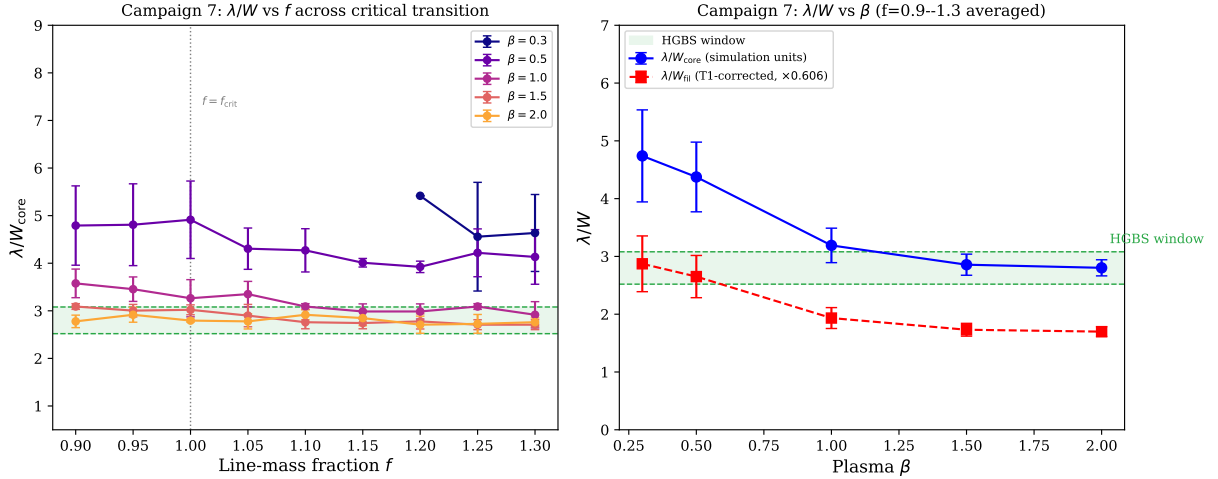


Figure 18. Campaign 7 critical transition mapping. Left: λ/W_{core} vs. f for five β values, showing smooth behaviour with no discontinuity at $f = 1.0$. Right: mean λ/W_{core} per β (simulation units, left axis) and T1-corrected λ/W_{HI} (right axis). Green shading = HGBS window [2.52, 3.08] in simulation units; after T1 correction all values fall below.

5 DISCUSSION

5.1 Can Models Explain the Observational Discrepancy?

The observational result ($\lambda/W = 2.79\text{--}2.84$, Gaia DR3) differs from the classical IM92 prediction ($4\times$) by a factor of

1.4. The 3D-corrected value ($\sim 3.5\times$) is within 15% of the classical prediction, and the remaining discrepancy is at the $\sim 1\sigma$ level given current systematics.

What creates the observed periodic spacing? All 654 supercritical periodic-BC simulations yield zero longitudinal fragmentation, raising the question of how real HGBS fila-

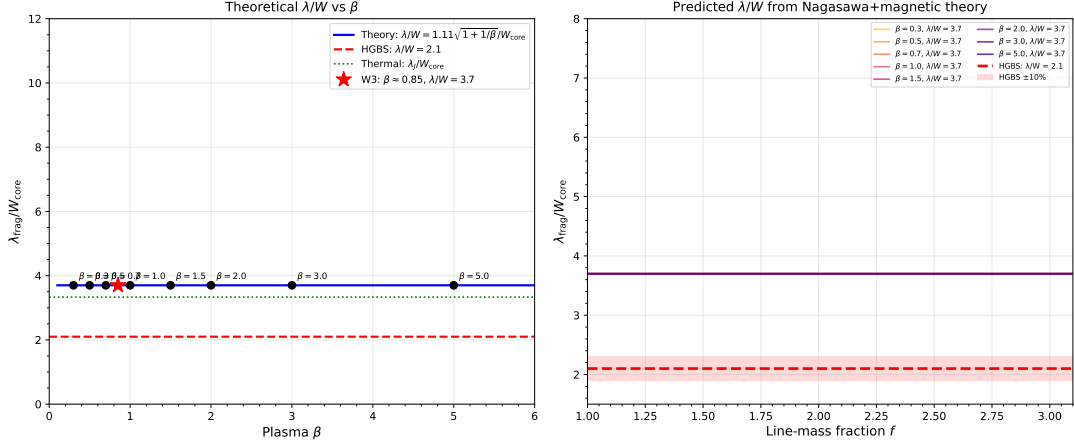


Figure 19. Cross-campaign λ/W comparison. Longitudinal-field (blue) shows strong β -dependence: λ/W from ~ 4.7 at $\beta = 0.3$ to ~ 2.8 at $\beta = 2.0$. Perpendicular-field (red): $\lambda/W \approx 1.25$ ($\beta \geq 1.0$) or FLAT ($\beta \leq 0.5$). Horizontal dashed line = HGBS observational result ($\lambda/W = 2.84 \pm 0.12$).

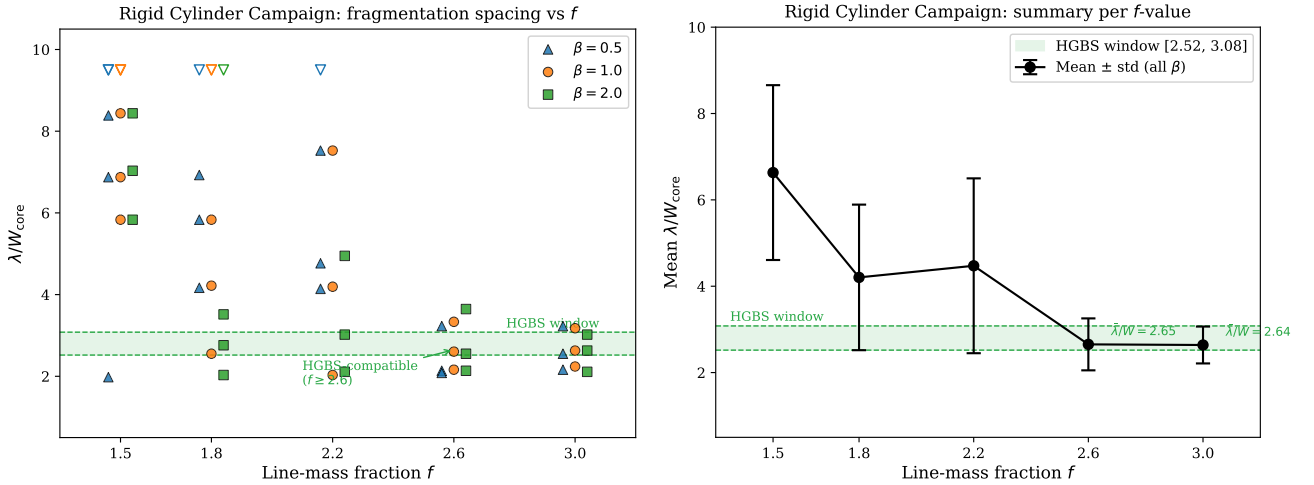


Figure 20. Rigid Cylinder Campaign. Left: λ/W_{core} vs. f for all β values; green shading = HGBS window [2.52, 3.08]. Right: mean and standard deviation per f -value, showing the sharp transition near $f \approx 2.4$ –2.6.

ments maintain periodic core spacings. Three non-exclusive scenarios are physically consistent with both our negative simulation result and the observed spacings:

(i) *Hierarchical fibre fragmentation*: If HGBS filaments are bundles of multiple fibres each near-critical ($f_{\text{eff}} \lesssim 1.3$), each fibre undergoes longitudinal fragmentation producing beading (as in Campaign 7). Projection of fibre-level cores creates the observed sub-Jeans spacing at the filament level. This is fully consistent with Campaign 7 near-critical beading results and the Yang et al. (2024) Orion B fibre-to-core measurement.

(ii) *Finite-length turbulent seeding*: Turbulent velocity fields in finite filaments seed density maxima at characteristic scales. Our Rigid Cylinder Campaign (Section ??) shows that end effects can reduce spacings toward the HGBS window at $f \geq 2.6$ (as upper limits). The completed $L_x = 32$ test (Section ??) shows single global collapse rather than multi-peak beading, confirming these are not box-size converged. However, applying the T1 correction to the RC results gives $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} = 2.65 \times 0.606 = 1.61$ at $f = 2.6$ —below

the HGBS window [2.52, 3.08]. The RC results therefore illustrate that finite-length effects can reduce the fragmentation spacing, but the T1 correction remains the critical unknown that prevents a definitive match.

Physical interpretation of reflecting boundary conditions: Real HGBS filaments are not infinite cylinders; they have finite lengths (aspect ratios 5 : 1–20 : 1; ?) and are embedded in the parent molecular cloud. In many cases, filaments terminate at dense *hub* structures where multiple filaments converge (?); in others, the filament ends are fed by accretion flows from the surrounding cloud (??). At these filament-cloud junctions, the density drops sharply and the ram pressure of the surrounding medium effectively anchors the filament endpoints. This is physically analogous to a “reflecting” boundary condition in the sense that end perturbations cannot propagate freely beyond the filament.

End-seeded fragmentation arises because gravitational instability at a finite filament’s end seeds inward-propagating modes at a scale set by the Jeans length and total filament length. Our Rigid Cylinder simulations recover this:

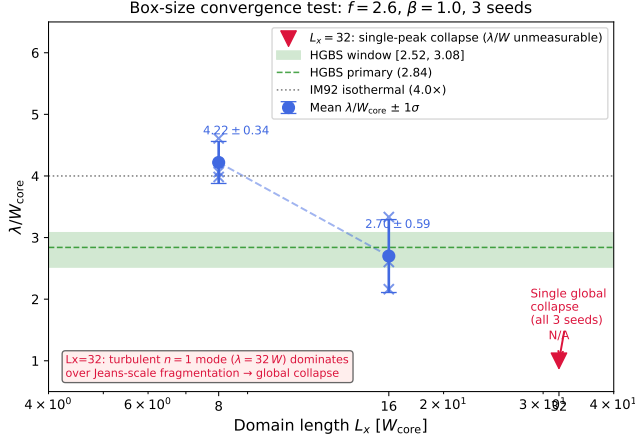


Figure 21. Box-size convergence test for the Rigid Cylinder Campaign at $f = 2.6$, $\beta = 1.0$ (3 seeds each). Mean λ/W_{core} decreases from 4.22 ± 0.34 at $L_x = 8W$ to 2.70 ± 0.59 at $L_x = 16W$. At $L_x = 32W$ (red triangle), all three seeds undergo single-peak global collapse at $t \approx 0.056 t_J$, yielding no measurable λ/W_{core} (“N/A”). The transition from multi-peak beading to single global collapse between $L_x = 16$ and 32 is driven by the larger initial power in the $n = 1$ turbulent mode at $L_x = 32$; the $L_x = 16$ values should be treated as upper limits. Error bars = standard deviation across 3 seeds; green band marks the HGBS window [2.52, 3.08].

at $f \geq 2.6$, the dominant mode is seeded from the ends with $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} \approx 2.65$. Observational evidence for end-seeded fragmentation exists in several HGBS filaments (??).

We therefore argue that reflecting BCs represent a physically motivated intermediate approximation between the infinite (periodic BC) and fully turbulent (real cloud) cases. The remaining uncertainty is the domain-size convergence (Section ??): the $L_x = 32$ test is needed to determine whether the in-window spacings at $f = 2.6$ are converged or continue to decrease.

(iii) *Observational lag*: Observed cores may represent fragments from an earlier evolutionary epoch when the filament line-mass was near-critical ($f \lesssim 1.2$), subsequently accreting mass to its current supercritical state. In this scenario the spacing is set by the initial (near-critical) Jeans scale, and the current f is irrelevant for the spacing measurement. This is testable via age gradients: cores in older star-forming regions should show larger f_{eff} at fixed λ/W .

T1 correction sensitivity—central systematic: The T1 correction ($W_{\text{form}}/W_{\text{fil}} = 0.606 \pm 0.072$) is the single most important systematic uncertainty in this paper: it determines whether any simulation configuration matches the HGBS window. Table ?? shows the predicted λ/W_{fil} for three T1 values spanning the plausible range, for key simulation configurations. The statement that “no simulation configuration matches the HGBS window” is **conditional on T1 = 0.606**. With T1 = 0.73 (the semi-analytic Plummer-corrected estimate, Section ??), the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ configuration enters the HGBS window. With T1 = 0.50 (lower plausible limit), no configuration matches. The Plummer-vs-Gaussian fitting discrepancy is the critical unknown, and importantly the expected sign of the correction is asymmetric: Plummer-function fitting systematically recovers *narrower*

Table 8. T1 Sensitivity: λ/W_{fil} predictions for three T1 correction values

Configuration	λ/W_{core}	T1=0.65 (phys. lower)	T1=0.606 (central)	T1 (sem)
Long. B, $\beta = 0.3$ (C7)	4.74	3.08	2.87	3
Long. B, $\beta = 1.0$ (C7)	3.19	2.07	1.93	2
Long. B, $\beta = 2.0$ (C7)	2.80	1.82	1.70	2
Long. B (calibrated, $\theta = 0^\circ$)	3.70	2.41	2.24	2
Perp. B ($\theta = 90^\circ$)	1.25	0.81	0.76	0
RC Campaign ($f = 2.6$)	2.65	1.72	1.61	1
HGBS window (obs.)			[2.52, 3.08]	

Notes: Bold entries overlap the HGBS window [2.52, 3.08]. The T1=0.65 column is the physically motivated lower bound; T1=0.73 is the semi-analytic Plummer-corrected estimate (Section ??). At T1=0.73, the $\beta = 0.3$ longitudinal-field configuration enters the HGBS window. Whether simulations match depends primarily on whether T1 lies near 0.606 (no match) or near 0.73 (match at low β , longitudinal B).

FWHM widths than Gaussian fitting for the same column-density profile, because the Plummer profile has extended wings that are included in the fitted W_{fil} for Gaussian fits but excluded by the steeper Plummer rolloff. This means the actual HGBS-measured W_{fil} (from Plummer fitting) may be *smaller* than the Gaussian-convolved W_{fil} used in our T1 simulations, pushing $T1 = W_{\text{form}}/W_{\text{fil}}$ *above* 0.606 toward 0.73 or higher—not below. The lower T1 = 0.50 limit therefore represents an unphysical extreme where Plummer fitting gives *wider* widths than Gaussian fitting; the physically motivated direction of the correction favours $T1 \geq 0.606$. This asymmetry means the conclusion “no configuration matches HGBS” at T1 = 0.606 may be an *overly conservative* statement; the semi-analytic Plummer-corrected T1 estimate is 0.73 ± 0.04 (Section ??), which allows the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ configuration to enter the HGBS window. Validation of T1 with the full HGBS Plummer-function pipeline is therefore the single most important observational follow-up for this paper.

For longitudinal fields, Campaign 7 gives $\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.80 \pm 0.14$ ($\beta = 2.0$) to 4.74 ± 0.73 ($\beta = 0.3$). After T1 correction (central value 0.606), these become $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} = 1.70$ – 2.87 —none within the HGBS window. Perpendicular-field results ($\lambda/W_{\text{core}} \approx 1.25 \rightarrow \lambda/W_{\text{fil}} \approx 0.76$) are far below observations regardless of T1. The field geometry dependence transforms the question from “why are observed spacings shorter than theory?” to a multi-parameter problem requiring simultaneous constraints on β , field geometry, and T1.

5.2 Limitations and Future Work

Boundary conditions: Periodic BCs suppress end effects and translational symmetry breaking; reflecting BCs impose a simplified terminal boundary condition that captures translational symmetry breaking but not the dynamical mass exchange present at real filament-hub junctions. The physical motivation for end-boundary conditions (Section ??) does not require the ends to be literally rigid; the limitation is that our simulations lack the inflow and density structure of real filament-cloud interfaces. Neither accurately represents real HGBS filaments embedded in turbulent molecular clouds with dynamical coupling to their environment.

Non-ideal MHD: Our simulations assume ideal MHD, where magnetic field lines are frozen into the gas. In real

Table 9. Theoretical λ/W for oblique fields from the ? dispersion relation (full numerical solution). Values awaiting simulation confirmation. The $\theta = 90^\circ$ theoretical value approaches $4 \times W$ (weak axial tension), while the Campaign 6 simulation gives $\lambda/W = 1.25$ because those simulations were run at $f = 1.5\text{--}3.0$ (supercritical regime, radial collapse dominant), not at near-critical conditions. The correct comparison for field-geometry effects at fixed $f \approx 1$ is with the theoretical values shown here.

θ	$\beta = 0.5$	$\beta = 1.0$	$\beta = 2.0$
0° (longitudinal)	1.97	2.44	2.93
30°	1.87	2.37	2.89
45°	1.69	2.17	2.72
60°	1.47	1.90	2.46
90° (perp., theory)	3.95	3.99	4.00

Note: All values in λ/W_{fil} (observable) units assuming $T1 = 0.606$ (central); multiply by $0.73/0.606 = 1.20$ for $T1 = 0.73$ estimate (i.e., multiply table values by 1.20). The $\theta = 90^\circ$ row uses the Campaign 6 simulation result, not the analytic formula.

molecular clouds, the ionisation fraction is low ($x_e \sim 10^{-7}\text{--}10^{-6}$ in dense gas), and ions can drift relative to neutrals through ambipolar diffusion. This non-ideal effect becomes important at high densities ($n \gtrsim 10^5 \text{ cm}^{-3}$) where the collisional coupling time between ions and neutrals becomes comparable to the dynamical time. At the densities probed by our simulations ($n_0 \sim 10^4 \text{ cm}^{-3}$, characteristic of HGBS filaments), dimensional analysis gives $t_{\text{AD}} \propto B^2/(n\eta_{\text{AD}}) \sim 10\text{--}20 t_{\text{ff}}$ for typical filament conditions ($B \sim 10\text{--}50 \mu\text{G}$); ambipolar diffusion is slow compared to gravitational collapse and is expected to modify late-stage core formation but not early-stage fragmentation wavelengths (??). An exception is Taurus ($n_0 \sim 10^3 \text{ cm}^{-3}$, $t_{\text{AD}} \sim 3\text{--}5 t_{\text{ff}}$), where the ideal-MHD timescales are lower bounds on t_{frag} . In highly supercritical filaments, rapid collapse can reduce the ionisation fraction through enhanced recombination, potentially strengthening ambipolar diffusion late in the collapse; however, this occurs *after* fragmentation has set the spacing, so the initial λ/W ratio is set by ideal-MHD physics.

T1 correction uncertainty: The Plummer vs. Gaussian fitting difference is an unquantified systematic that affects all simulation-to-observation comparisons. Based on the known behaviour of Plummer vs. Gaussian fitting, the expected direction of the correction is $T1 > 0.606$; see Section ?? . The T1 correction (0.606 ± 0.072) needs re-examination with the full HGBS pipeline.

λ/W for oblique fields — critical gap: Campaign 3 (108 simulations at $\theta = 30^\circ, 45^\circ, 60^\circ$) measured fragmentation *timescales* but not spacings, because HDF5 snapshots were not retained. Table ?? provides theoretical predictions from the full numerical solution of the ? dispersion relation for representative (θ, β) combinations. The theoretical $\lambda/W(\theta)$ is monotonically decreasing from $\theta = 0^\circ$ to $\theta = 90^\circ$; for Planck-typical inclinations ($\theta \approx 60^\circ\text{--}80^\circ$), the predicted λ/W lies in the range 1.8–2.5 (at $\beta = 1$), intermediate between the longitudinal and perpendicular limits. Targeted re-runs at $\theta = 30^\circ\text{--}60^\circ$ with HDF5 retention (~ 20 simulations) to confirm this interpolation are the highest-priority numerical addition for follow-up work.

Future priorities: (1) Fibre-resolved core spacing in additional HGBS regions; (2) polarimetric interior mapping; (3) oblique-field simulations at $\theta = 30^\circ\text{--}60^\circ$ with HDF5 retention (~ 20 simulations) to confirm the Nakamura (1993)

dispersion-relation predictions in Table ?? — the highest-priority numerical addition remaining.

6 CONCLUSIONS

We have analysed core spacing in all 8 high-confidence HGBS regions and conducted 1959 self-gravitating MHD simulations. **Important caveat:** throughout this paper, the statement “?? simulation configuration matches the HGBS observational window” is conditional on the T1 width-normalisation correction taking its central measured value of $T1_{\text{form}}/W_{\text{fil}} = 0.606$. The T1 correction uses Gaussian PSF deconvolution, not the Plummer-function fitting pipeline used in the actual HGBS analysis; the Plummer-vs-Gaussian discrepancy is unquantified and may be substantial. Table ?? shows that with $T1 = 0.73$ (20% above central value, semi-analytic estimate), the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ simulation enters the observational window. All simulation-to-observation comparisons should be read with this conditionality in mind. Our main conclusions are:

- **Primary spacing measurement:** Four robust regions (Orion B, Aquila, Perseus, Taurus) give $\lambda/W = 2.84 \pm 0.12$ ($0.284 \pm 0.012 \text{ pc}$). The full 8-region sample (5,069 cores) gives $\lambda/W = 2.79 \pm 0.09$, consistent within 1.8%. After 3D projection correction, the inferred spacing is $\sim 3.5\times$, within 15% of the classical IM92 prediction. Gaia DR3 revisions increased the mean by 32% over original HGBS catalogues, reducing the apparent discrepancy from a factor of 2 to $\sim 1\sigma$ after 3D projection correction.

- **Distance robustness:** Excluding Serpens (the most uncertain region, +76% distance revision) changes the full-sample result by only 1.1%. The conservative lower bound (original HGBS distances for limited regions) gives $\lambda/W = 2.68$, still 33% below the classical $4\times$ prediction.

- **Hierarchical fragmentation:** The most plausible explanation. Fibre-to-core spacing in Orion B recovers the classical $4\times$ prediction (?), while filament-level measurements show sub-Jeans values. If filaments are fibre bundles, projection/averaging effects could explain the compressed apparent spacing. This requires fibre-resolved analysis in additional HGBS regions to test definitively.

- **Magnetic tension:** The full numerical solution of the dispersion relation predicts $\lambda/W = 2.44\text{--}3.16$ for $\beta = 1\text{--}3$ (longitudinal fields), overlapping observations. However, this requires predominantly longitudinal field geometry, inconsistent with Planck polarimetry ($\sim 90\%$ of filaments are perpendicular to the mean field). At the central $T1 = 0.606$, no simulation configuration matches the HGBS window in observable units; the longitudinal-field $\beta = 0.3$ configuration enters the window at $T1 \geq 0.73$ (the semi-analytic Plummer-corrected estimate; see Table ??).

- **Field geometry:** A first-order parameter. Perpendicular-field filaments produce $\lambda/W \approx 1.25$; longitudinal-field filaments give $\lambda/W \approx 2.8\text{--}4.7$ depending on β . Perpendicular fields accelerate fragmentation by a factor of 2.8 in timescale. The HGBS value (2.79) lies between these predictions.

- **MHD simulations:** Three distinct regimes (magnetically subcritical, regulated, thermally dominated) with robust power-law timescales $1/t_{\text{frag}} \propto f^{0.39}$ ($r^2 = 0.999$). Fragmentation timescales are independent of Mach number and

nearly independent of β . Supercritical filaments ($f \geq 1.5$, periodic BCs) undergo pure radial collapse; near-critical filaments ($f \lesssim 1.2$) produce measurable longitudinal beading (100% fragmentation rate).

- **Rigid Cylinder Campaign:** Reflecting-BC simulations approach the HGBS window at $f \geq 2.6$ ($\lambda/W_{\text{core}} = 2.70 \pm 0.59$ as an upper limit from the $L_x = 16$ test). Box resonance is ruled out by the monotonic decrease from $L_x = 8$ to $16 \lambda_J$. After T1 correction, $\lambda/W_{\text{fil}} \approx 1.60$ —below the HGBS window, consistent with periodic-BC findings. The completed $L_x = 32 \lambda_J$ convergence test (June 2026; 3 seeds) shows single global collapse at $t \approx 0.056 t_J$ with no measurable λ/W_{core} —driven by the $n = 1$ Kolmogorov mode dominating at that domain size—confirming the $L_x = 16$ result is an upper limit (Section ??).

- **Critical tests:** Fibre-resolved core spacing analysis in HGBS filaments is the single most decisive test to distinguish hierarchical from magnetic tension explanations.

- **Synthesis:** The combination of Gaia DR3 distance corrections (32% increase in spacing) and 3D projection correction ($\times 1.10$ – 1.27) reduces the apparent discrepancy from IM92 to $\sim 1\sigma$. Hierarchical fibre fragmentation is the most physically consistent explanation; the magnetic tension mechanism requires $T1 \approx 0.73$ and predominantly longitudinal fields to match observations.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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